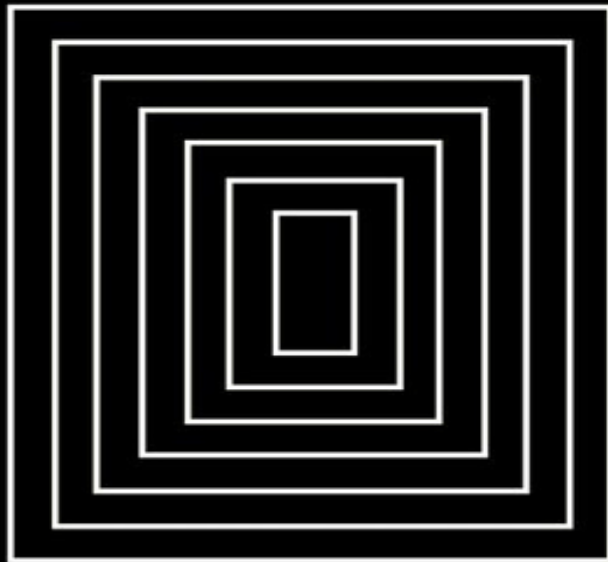


B. Pfaus

ALICE MUNRO



THE GOLDEN DOG

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CONTENTS

Alice Munro

Dance of the Happy Shades (1968)

Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You (1974)

Lives of Girls and Women (1971)

Who Do You Think You Are? (1978)

The Moons of Jupiter (1982)

Selected Bibliography

ALICE MUNRO

“It is terrible when you find out that your
idea of reality is not the real reality.”

“The Spanish Lady”

Something I've Been Meaning To Tell You
p. 141

*I'm very, very excited by what you might call the surface of life. . . It's just things about people, the way they look, the way they sound, the way things smell, the way everything is that you go through every day. It seems to me very important to do something with this. . . It seems to me very important to be able to get at the exact tone or texture of how things are. I can't really claim that it is linked to any kind of religious feeling about the world, and yet that might come closest to describing it.*¹

This desire to “get at the exact tone or texture of how things are” dominates and gives Alice Munro’s writing its characteristic qualities, evidenced in her 5 published volumes: four collections of short stories, *Dance of the Happy Shades* (1968), *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* (1971), *Who Do You Think You Are?* (1978), *The Moons of Jupiter* (1982) and a collection of self-contained stories *Lives of Girls and Women* (1971), which Munro classifies as a novel.² She started writing stories in her early teens aware that:

I had a different view of the world and one that would bring me into great trouble and ridicule if it were exposed. I learned very early to disguise everything and perhaps the escape into making stories was necessary.³

From her early teens, she began recording in a vein of reminiscent realism, the events and people of ordinary life around her in south western rural Ontario. Born in 1931, she was raised on a fox farm near Wingham. After spending nearly 20 years in Vancouver with her husband and family, she returned in 1972 to south western Ontario, and now lives with her family in Clinton, a small rural town near Wingham. She acknowledges that one of her strengths is that she is a regional writer, in that she is able to feel “the texture” of the area and understands and captures “the essence of a particular time at a particular place,” an understanding she feels can only be captured “where your roots are”⁴; south western Ontario is “a very rooted kind of place. I think that the kind of writing I do,” Munro claims, “is almost anachronistic because it's so rooted in one time and most people,

even of my age, do not have a place like this any more.”⁵ Much of Munro’s writing springs from her sense of the place, set in her mythical Wawanash River area of Jubilee, the setting for *Lives of Girls and Women* and stories like “The Peace of Utrecht” in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and “The Found Boat” and “Boys and Girls” and “The Ottawa Valley” in *Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You*. All of her stories, including the linked or episodic stories, draw on factual material from her childhood and adolescent experiences and from the lives she observed around her, sometimes as, “changed versions of real incidents” and definitely are “in emotion — completely autobiographical.” Her father’s background as a trapper, fox farmer and poultry farmer is used in stories like “Boys and Girls,” “Images” and *Lives of Girls and Women*. Her first really painfully autobiographical story, “The Peace of Utrecht” and the closest Munro has come to “pure autobiography,” “The Ottawa Valley,” are stories about her attempts to come to terms with her mother’s Parkinson’s disease and her death in 1959, stories she feels she could never have told while her mother was alive. Often she doesn’t feel free to use material from her own experience until ten or fifteen years later because Munro says often, “I don’t know what I think about something until it’s years and years past, even something in my own life.”⁶ Most of her stories consequently are episodic stories narrated through the wisdom and maturity of hindsight in an attempt by Munro at control over her own past experiences. Writing is for Munro:

a way of getting on top of experience; this is different from one’s experience of the things in the world, the experience with other people and with oneself, which can be, which is, so confusing, and humiliating and difficult and by dealing with it, this way, though, I don’t mean that I deal directly with personal experience, though I do but after quite a long time has elapsed. I think it’s a way of getting control.⁷

With the writing of *Dance of The Happy Shades* and *Lives of Girls and Women*, Munro feels in control of the ghosts of her childhood but realizes that “dealing with the ghosts of one’s maturity is more difficult,” a task she is currently undertaking.

Munro remained an obscure literary figure, publishing her stories in magazines like the *Tamarack Review*, the *Queen's Quarterly* and *Canadian Forum*. Everything changed in 1968 when her first collection of short stories *Dance of The Happy Shades*, written over a period of eleven years, won the Governor General's Award for fiction. One of the stories, "Boys and Girls," produced by Atlantis Films Limited in association with the CBC, won an American Academy Award in 1984 in the Live Action Short Film category. The publication in 1971 of *Lives of Girls and Women*, won high acclaim as winner of The Canadian Booksellers Association International Book Year Award. The publication of *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* in 1974 and winning the Governor General's Award for fiction in 1978 with *Who Do You Think You Are?* have established Alice Munro as one of Canada's foremost current writers. The publication of *The Moons of Jupiter* in 1982 afforded Munro high public acclaim. Munro, however, a very private person, shuns this acclaim, feeling that as a public persona she would have to operate "in disguises, feeling if I do to a certain point what the world expects of me, then they'll leave me alone."⁸ This she feels would lead to "a loss of self" and eventually, it would make her paralyzed. "I wouldn't be able to write at all because I wouldn't be having any real feelings about things"⁹; and "real feelings about things" lie at the very heart of Munro's writing which she works seriously at, with "such pain and difficulty" ten to fourteen hours a day.

When she gets an idea for a story, her first task is to find out why it feels important to her. This is a process she describes as "getting it right." Most of her material then goes through five or six arduous revisions on which Munro works painstakingly slowly. "There are parts of *Lives of Girls and Women* that have certainly been through the typewriter thirty times," she says. This process of painful revision gives her writing its characteristic compactness and delicacy of language, exactness of observation and "emotional exactness. . . .an exactness of resonance." The following passage from "Images" (one of Munro's favourite stories) illustrates the richness of her prose style, which is often more akin to poetry with its vivid images:

The man crossed my path somewhere ahead, continuing down to the river. People say they have been paralyzed by fear, but I was transfixed, as if struck by lightning, and what hit me did not feel like fear so much as recognition. I was not surprised. This is the sight that does not surprise you, the thing you have always known was there that comes so naturally, moving delicately and contentedly and in no hurry, as if it was made, in the first place, from a wish of yours, a hope of something final, terrifying. All my life I had known there was a man like this and he was behind doors, around the corner at the dark end of a hall. So now I saw him and just waited, like a child in an old negative, electrified against the dark noon sky, with blazing hair and burned-out Orphan Annie Eyes.

(*Dance*, p. 38)

Behind all of Munro's work is a single moral impulse exemplified by this passage that reality on its different cognitive levels must be confronted and felt, however painful it might be. Her narrators and protagonists, with the exceptions of Dick in "Thanks For The Ride" and Mr. Lougheed in "Walking on Water" are women, frequently involved in this process: trying to break out of the disguises and evasions of the conventional world into the light of "truth," through the universal experience of growing up into the awareness of the complexities of human affairs and emotions which constitute experience. The frequent pain and humour of this process colours all of her writing. Actually what Munro likes best about her writing is when she has made something funny and someone laughs. "I think when you've made something funny, you've achieved some kind of reality. That's what I'm trying to get."¹⁰

Her stories abound with humour often subtle but always borne out of life's ironies and incongruities. In "An Ounce of Cure," the narrator recalls "all the stupid, sad, half-ashamed things" people like herself, in love do, culminating through "disastrous innocence" in her getting drunk while babysitting at the Berryman's. In "Forgiveness in Families" the narrator wryly comments on her brother, a sort of balding, 34-year-old Hare Krishna follower who collects welfare and calls himself "a priest." Every episode in *Lives of Girls and Women* is narrated with Munro's sense of humour: Uncle

Benny's mail order marriage to "that madwoman" who'd "thrown the kettle through the window because there wasn't any water in it," and who had said "she'd set fire to the house because he had brought her the wrong brand of cigarettes"; the day Del had bitten Mary Agnes Oliphant's arm at Uncle Craig's funeral; Del's first sexual consummation not at all like the idea of "a ceremonial beginning like a curtain going up on the last act of a play" but, instead his belt buckle pressed painfully into her stomach, as they lean against the house, she wrestles with her panties tangled around her feet, worrying that the white gleam of his buttocks might give them away to anybody passing on the street, until they crash unceremoniously into the peony border. Just as Rose in *Who Do You Think You Are?* has a need "to picture things, to pursue absurdities," so too, Munro's comic vision is never far from, "the shameless, marvellous, shattering absurdity with which the plots of life, though not of fiction, are improvised." (*Dance*, p. 87)

Munro defines the writing process as, "a straining of something immense and varied, a whole dense vision of the world, into whatever confines the writer has learned to make for it."¹¹ All of Munro's short stories present the reader with Munro's vision of two worlds which she sees as having an essential and irreconcilable tension between the two sets of values inherent in each world: the chaotic, natural world or "other country" and "the world" or social garrison of conventionality, terms of the Munro canon supplied by the title story in her first collection, *Dance of the Happy Shades*. Characters like Miss Marsalles in "Dance of The Happy Shades," Eileen in "Memorial," Uncle Benny in *Lives of Girls and Women*, or Becky Tyde in *Who Do You Think You Are?* inhabit Munro's "other country," a naturalistic world of chaos and disorder, free of social inhibition. Some of Munro's characters like Mrs. Fullerton in "The Shiny Houses" inhabit "the other country" by choice; many, however, like Myra in "The Day of the Butterfly," Lois in "Thanks For The Ride" and Eugene in "Walking on Water" are outside the social garrison by virtue of poverty, disease, deformity, old age or mental aberration. However, these characters, like Flo in *Who Do You Think You Are?* enjoy a kind of honest, spontaneous individualism in contrast to the characters in the conventional garrison like Jane in "Memorial" whom Munro portrays protecting themselves metaphorically from the existential reality of "the other country" by playing roles, wearing disguises and masks (both visual and verbal), and engaging

in ritualistic ceremonies. In some stories like “The Time of Death” and “Executioners” Munro suggests that the external deformities and violences of “the other country” are simply the symbolic transferences of the unseen, masked disfigurements of the characters of “the world.” Like the grandmother in “Winter Wind” and Aunts Grace and Elspeth in *Lives of Girls and Women*, these characters consequently lead inauthentic lives of “unconsummated relationships” and betrayals of the self in a world of half-truths: “true lies,” resulting in fraud for everyone.

The narrator in Munro’s fiction stands uneasily between two positions: on the one hand she is an active participant in or even an instigator of the action and on the other hand she stands apart from it as a kind of intuitive moral critic, on the edge of discovery about herself or of some revelations about the nature of her world which not only threaten her day-to-day values but also her concept of cosmic order itself. The reader can discern in the five collections of short stories, a progressive development in Munro’s protagonists who move from an awareness, or glimpse into the existence of the two worlds with an almost nostalgic feeling of regret for what is lost and yet not understood in the stories in *Dance of The Happy Shades* who like the young narrator in “Walker Brothers Cowboy” after a visit to “the other country” feels her father’s life:

flowing back from our car in the last of the afternoon, darkening and turning strange, like a landscape that has an enchantment on it, making it kindly, ordinary and familiar while you are looking at it, but changing it, once your back is turned, into something you will never know, with all kinds of weathers, and distances you cannot imagine.

(*Dance*, p. 18)

Del in *Lives of Girls and Women* becomes aware of the disparate nature of reality but nevertheless has a somewhat naive belief in her freedom in “real life.” (*Real Life* was initially intended by Munro to be the title of this book.) The epilogue story, “The Photographer,” suggests in Del’s misconceptions about the mad Bobby Sherriff her ultimate inability to really know the

nature of reality. Rising on his toes like a plump ballerina, he sends Del a communiqué of sorts from “the other country”:

This action, accompanied by his delicate smile, appeared to be a joke not shared with me so much as displayed for me, and it seemed also to have a concise meaning, a stylized meaning — to be a letter, or a whole word, in an alphabet I did not know.

(*Lives*, p. 211)

The stories in *Something I've Been Meaning To Tell You*, feature protagonists who are older and more experienced in “real life.” These protagonists are moving to the bitter realization that the two worlds are irreconcilable and there may ultimately be no choices between the value systems of the two worlds. As Eileen in “Memorial” realizes, “the only thing we can hope for is that we lapse now and then into reality.”

In the early stories, Rose, the protagonist in *Who Do You Think You Are?* is reminiscent of the naïveté of Munro’s young protagonists in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and Del in *Lives of Girls and Women*, but like the older protagonists in *Something I've Been Meaning To Tell You*, Rose struggles to compromise the two worlds moving finally to the realization and acceptance in middle age that role playing conventions, of “the world” are perhaps a valid and necessary means of defining existence against the fact that a sort of moral chaos rules everything and that beyond the quest for meaning, “learning to survive, no matter with what craveness and caution, what shocks and forebodings,” one can find ultimately nothing tangible or lasting exterior to one’s own reality, to give meaning to life — regardless of which world one inhabits. However, in response to critics who say Rose doesn’t get anything; everything fails, Munro replies, “she gets something out of life. She learns something,”¹² because “learning to survive . . . is not the same as being miserable. It is too interesting.” (*Who*, p. 28) Consequently, there is a recurring paradoxical pattern running throughout Munro’s stories: the dramatization of the conjunction of existential desperation and existential possibility within a total vision that is actually much closer to faith than it is to despair. Worlds do not qualitatively change at the conclusion of Munro’s stories and often situations remain unresolved

or even worsen; however, her protagonists become cognizant of possible valid realities beyond the conformity of the social garrison with its restrictive and fraudulent roles, rituals, disguises and masks and, like Eileen in “Memorial” start, “to test those values that we live by,” even if new judgements and solutions are not possible. The reader can sense Munro’s protagonists moving to a more complete and “whole dense vision of the world” which at times because of its nature must remain an almost inarticulated and often paradoxical vision. At the conclusion of *Who Do You Think You Are?*, Rose expresses the essential paradox in Munro’s continuous attempts to portray through her writing, “the exact tone or texture of how things are”:

There seemed to be feelings which can only be spoken of in translation; perhaps they could only be acted on in translation; not speaking of them and not acting on them is the right course to take because translation is dubious.

(*Who*, p. 210)

FOOTNOTES

1. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, (Toronto: Anansi, 1973), p. 241
2. *Ibid.*, p. 258
3. *Ibid.*, p. 246
4. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," John Metcalf, *Journal of Canadian Fiction*, 1, No. 4, (Fall, 1972), p. 56
5. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, p. 249
6. Alice Munro, "The Past, the Present and Alice Munro" *Saturday Night*, (November, 1979), p. 22
7. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, p. 245
8. *Ibid.*, p. 251
9. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," p. 61
10. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, p. 252
11. Alice Munro, "Author's Commentary," *Sixteen By Twelve*, ed. John Metcalf (Toronto: Ryerson, 1970), p. 126
12. Alice Munro, "Who Do You Think You Are? Review-Interview with Alice Munro." *Room of One's Own*, 4, No. 4 (1979), p. 5

Dance of the Happy Shades (1968)

“Maybe just by walking up and down, driving up and down, going places, the rest of the world proved its absurdity. You see that judgement on the faces of people looking out of windows, sitting on front steps in some little towns; so deeply, deeply uncaring they are, as if they had sources of disillusionment which they would keep, with some satisfaction, in the dark.”

“Thanks for The Ride”

p. 44

All but three of the fifteen stories in Munro's first collection of short stories, *Dance of The Happy Shades* are written from the point of view of a child or adolescent, modified to some extent by the passage of time and new insights between an incident and its recording. In only one is the narrator a male. In each, the characters are seen in a strongly and vividly presented rural or small town setting in which "the surfaces of life," its textures, sounds and smells are described with exactness of observation and richness of language. Although the stories have no formal sequence they effectively trace the development of sensitive protagonists coming into womanhood and an awareness of the realities of life. Collectively they capture the vitality and the stagnation of rural and small town life in the 30s and 40s; the barriers between the young and the old, the poor and the affluent, the sick and the well. Captured too is the lack of genuine communication between family members, friends and lovers resulting in "unconsummated relationships," (a term that originates in "The Peace of Utrecht" that aptly applies to situations in every Munro story) and the resultant sense of isolation. The pressure to conform and the failure of individuality within the social garrison pervades every story. Throughout these stories, intangible or irrational impulses between the protagonist and some other element — other characters, the past, a code of morality or behaviour as stories shift between the rational and the irrational, between the familiar comfortable world and uncertainty and illusion — create a tension which gives Munro's writing its haunting and disturbing quality, as the reader, too, through the sensorium of the protagonist, grapples with the question of reality.

The title story in *Dance of The Happy Shades* exemplifies Munro's vision of two worlds. Miss Marsalles, an aging, impoverished piano teacher hosts her annual "party." The guests, the middle-class mothers, perceive that she looks "like a character in a masquerade, like the feverish, fancied-up courtesan of an unpleasant Puritan imagination" as she greets them. Ironically, it soon becomes evident that the guests are the real actors in the "masquerade." At one time, when Miss Marsalles' address was in fashionable Rosedale, the annual party had, "solidarity, it had tradition, in its serenely out-of-date ways it had style. Everything was always as

expected.” Now, however, her aging sister lies upstairs, stricken by a stroke, while downstairs “flies buzz over the table, settle on the sandwiches” and the faces of the reluctant guests begin to show the effects of a fairly general uneasiness as the socially conscious mothers no longer feel the old assurances of tradition. They felt drawn to Miss Marsalles’ party out of allegiance, “to the ceremonies of their childhood, to the more exacting pattern of life.” Now, however, there is a feeling in the story, characteristic of Munro’s stories, that, “things are getting out of hand, anything may happen.”

The unexpected and disorderly arrival of the retarded students from Greenhill School who are going to play their musical pieces shocks and dismays the trapped audience. There is an atmosphere in the room of “some freakish inescapable dream.” Keeping their outward social masks intact, inwardly, the mothers call them, “little idiots” and scream, “WHAT KIND OF PARTY IS THIS?” making every effort not to look at these children. The beautiful performance of the musical piece: Dance of the Happy Shades by the retarded dolored Boyle, a performance much superior to those of their own children, produces in the mothers, “a more profound anxiety to those of their own children, produces in the mothers, “a more profound anxiety than before as if reminded of something that they had forgotten.” Knowledge of a freer, and more profoundly natural emotional reality has been repressed by these inhibited followers of tradition and ritual. In contrast to the anxiety of the mothers, Miss Marsalles finds the performance, “natural and satisfying” and “nor does it seem that she regards this girl with any more wonder than the other children from Greenhill School who love her or the rest of us, who do not.” The narrator, through her glimpse into “the other country” has become aware of the differences between the two worlds:

. . .the girl’s ability which is undeniable but after all useless, out of place, is not really something that anyone wants to talk about. To Miss Marsalles such a thing is acceptable, but to other people, people who live in the world it is not.

(Dance, p. 223)

She knows that the musical experience is, “that one communiqué from the other country where she lives that prevents her from saying as expected, ‘Poor Miss Marsalles’.”

In a story, Munro often uses vivid details of the settings evoking images that often recur in other stories within the book, to typify the contrasting characteristics of these two worlds. The juxtaposition of the two worlds is typified in the description of the houses in “The Shining Houses”: the neat and orderly suburban houses of “the world” and disheveled and randomly built houses of “the other country” just as she does in her description of the houses in “The Time of Death.”

. . . houses like Mrs. Fullerton’s had been separated from each other by uncut forest and a jungle of wild blackberry and salmonberry bushes; these surviving houses, with thick smoke coming out of their chimneys, walls unpainted and patched . . . these appeared every so often among the large new houses of Mimosa and Marigold and Heather Drive — dark, enclosed, expressing something like savagery in their disorder and the steep, unmatched angles of roofs and lean-tos; not possible on these streets, but there.

(*Dance*, p. 24)

The houses on these streets had, “no open straightforward plan, no order that an outsider could understand” in contrast to the bright shiny houses, “those ingenuously similar houses that looked calmly out at each other, all the way down the street.”

Mrs. Fullerton, an inhabitant of “these streets” is an eccentric, a social recluse who did not pay social calls and by the standards of the inhabitants of “those ingenuously similar houses,” she isn’t “exactly a charming old lady.” However, Mary, an inhabitant of Garden Place, does not want to endorse the petition to have her house (a blight on the symbolically named “Garden Place” suburb) torn down. She recognizes in Mrs. Fullerton’s good humoured stories about Mr. Fullerton’s desertion and her simple acceptance of her own reality that there are people whose lives can be seen in terms of a “pure reality.” Mary realizes that, “most of the people she knew had lives like her own, in which things were not sorted out yet,” but if she voiced

opposition to her neighbours attempts to remove this misfit from their midst, that they would all smile, “in a rather special way” and she would find herself served up, “as a conversational delight for the next coffee party.” Opting for conformity (which is a characteristic trait of Munro’s protagonists), Mary concludes that, “There is nothing you can do at present but put your hands in your pockets and keep a disaffected heart.”

Mary’s relationship with Mrs. Fullerton has, however, opened her perception of reality regarding the existence of two worlds and, “it occurred to her that they were right for themselves, for whatever it was they had to be.” Even though her neighbours, typifying the strength of the social garrison, are, “people who win,” she also sees the enduring power of the “other country”:

Outside it was quite dark, the white houses were growing dim, the clouds breaking and breaking and smoke blowing from Mrs. Fullerton’s chimney. The pattern of Garden Place, so assertive in the daytime, seemed to shrink at night into the raw black mountainside.

(Dance, p. 29)

An awareness, then, of “the other country,” inhabited by naturalistic, authentic characters is felt by the protagonists who are of “the world,” but like Mary in “Shining Houses” they remain garrisoned, keeping “a disaffected heart” believing, “there is nothing you can do at present” because, as the narrator of “Dance of The Happy Shades” knows, the reality and validity of the other country is, “not really something that anybody wants to talk about.” In “Thanks for The Ride,” Dick is also aware that most people cannot accept and consequently keep, “in the dark” their knowledge of a chaotic, disordered and naturalistic reality:

Maybe just by walking up and down, driving up and down, going places, the rest of the world proved its absurdity. You see that judgement on the faces of people looking out of windows, sitting on front steps in some little towns; so deeply, deeply uncaring they are, as if they had sources of disillusionment which they would keep, with some satisfaction, in the dark.

(*Dance*, p. 44)

Characters in the stories who inhabit the conventional world protect themselves from this knowledge of the world's "absurdity" and, "the shameless, marvellous shattering absurdity with which the plots of life . . . are improvised," through ritualistic role playing and the wearing of verbal masks: lies, half-truths and secrets. This forms a motif developed by interconnected metaphors running throughout the 4 volumes of stories: a motif that becomes increasingly more strident with each book. Characters like Miss Marsalles and Mrs. Fullerton have no need for such subterfuge.

As seen in the women in "Dance of The Happy Shades" who are drawn together annually by, "the ceremonies of their childhood, to the more exacting pattern of life," Munro's characters in "the world" are motivated and protected by ritual, evidenced in "Boys and Girls," "The Peace of Utrecht," "Day of the Butterfly," and "The Time of Death." In "Boys and Girls," the young girl feels that, "work in the house was endless, dreary and peculiarly depressing; work done out of doors and in my father's service, was ritualistically important." She later discovers, however, when the horse is to be shot that she is "on Flora's side and that made me no use to anybody not even her." When Flora escapes, the narrator is sent to shut the gate in the yard to entrap Flora; however, once there, she opened it as wide as possible even though she had made no conscious decision to do this. Holding the gate open she lets Flora run through. The horse, however, is captured and shot regardless. She learns from this experience that her intuitive feelings are more important than work ritualistically done in her father's service. However, she, "no longer felt safe," and finds herself now tearfully outside the circle encompassed by Laird, her father and ritualistic work.

"The Peace of Utrecht" is Munro's "first really painfully autobiographical story." In an interview with John Metcalf, she explains that stories written after "The Peace of Utrecht," "tend to all draw on autobiographical material"; they are autobiographical in "emotional reality" rather than factual events. Some stories are actually "changed versions of real incidents."¹ "The Peace of Utrecht" is narrated through the persona of a woman who has escaped the horror of ritualistic living in Jubilee and who

tries to convince her sister, Maddy, to do likewise. Helen returns after an absence of ten years to attend her mother's funeral. She notes that:

the rhythm of life in Jubilee is primitively seasonal. Deaths occur in winter; marriages are celebrated in the summer.

(Dance, p. 194)

The townsfolk talk of her mother, "so gently and ceremoniously . . . I realize that she became one of the town's possessions," despite the fact that she was a recluse, kept at home because of the bizarre side effects of her disease that made her daughters feel she was "a tasteless sideshow." In death, however, she fits into the "rhythm of life," in Jubilee.

Helen sees her sister, "making every effort to belong with these people and that shortly she would succeed." Ironically, Helen senses that she too plays a false social role with Maddy, while visiting her in Jubilee.

Maddy and I, though we speak cheerfully of our enjoyment of so long and intimate a visit will be relieved when it is over. Silence disturbs us. We laugh immoderately. I am afraid — very likely we are both afraid — that when the moment comes to say goodbye, unless we are very quick to kiss and fervently mockingly squeeze each other's shoulders, we will have to look straight into the desert that is between us and acknowledge that we are not merely indifferent; at heart we reject each other, and so for that past we make so much of sharing, we do not really share it at all. . .

(Dance, p. 190)

No wonder Helen, who has escaped the restrictive life of Jubilee, in a moment of angst, fears that she and Maddy like Aunt Aunnie and Auntie Lou may be ultimately trapped in the typified relationships of aging sisters. Helen is horrified at the prospect of:

Maddy and myself, grown old, caught back in the web of sisterhood after everything else has disappeared; making tea for some young

loved and essentially unimportant relative — and exhibiting just such a polished relationship

(Dance, p. 203)

As she watches her old aunts, she wonders:

if old people play such stylized and simplified roles with us because they are afraid that anything more honest might try our patience, or if they do it out of delicacy — to fill the social time — when in reality they feel so far away from us that there is no possibility of communicating with us at all

(Dance, p. 204)

The spinster sister, Maddy, with her secretive relationship with Fred Powell and her own teasing ritualistic games, has stayed during the last ten years in a sacrificial role to nurse her dying mother until she had her hospitalized because she couldn't go on. She wanted her own life. To Helen's suggestion that Maddy now, "take your life . . . go away, don't stay here," Maddy can only hide behind, "old foolish ritual phrases of despair" asking repeatedly, "But why can't I, Helen? Why can't I?"

In "Day of the Butterfly," Myra Sayla is an outsider by reason of her foreign background, her dress, and later her fatal illness. The other girls in her grade at school shun and mock her whenever possible. Walking to school one day, the narrator, typical of Munro's protagonists in that she is an individual fighting for precarious social survival within the norm, sees that, "a role was shaping for me that I could not resist playing," and she offers Myra friendship in the symbolic gift of a little tin butterfly from her Cracker Jack box. In talking to Myra, Helen is amazed that Myra has human dimensions, "apart from her role at the school" that the other girls have assigned for her. Nevertheless, she is grateful that Myra doesn't pin the butterfly on her dress because, if someone asked her where she got it, and she told them, what could she say? She knows that with this gift, a communiqué of sorts from within the garrison, she jeopardizes her own shaky position within the norm.

When Myra is hospitalized, the girls organize a birthday party for Myra, who because of a fatal disease is, “so entirely impressively set free of all the rules and conditions” of their lives. The party is in fact a “fashionable” social event for the girls who begin, “to talk of her as if she were something we owned,” and her party “became a cause.” Helen is called back to Myra’s bed in the hospital after all the other chosen bedside visitors have left, and is given a leatherette case by Myra. Helen, in fear of the “future in which she had found this place for me” doesn’t want to take the case, but cannot, “think how to get out of it, what lie to tell.” Dismissed from the room by a nurse, Helen flees the hospital, “set free by the barriers which now closed about Myra, her unknown, exalted, ether-smelling hospital world and by the treachery of my own heart.”

Following one’s naturalistic, intuitive feelings, as the girl in “Boys and Girls” learns, and as Helen in “Day of the Butterfly” fears, ultimately places one outside the social garrison with its comforting ritualistic roles. However, Munro shows that those who chose “the world” and its comfortable norms find themselves like Maddy in “The Peace of Utrecht” paralyzed, unable to possess her own life or like Helen in “Day of The Butterfly” imprisoned by the treachery of her conformity. “The Time of Death” shows a child, an outsider who desperately wants into the garrison. Characters in Munro’s “other country” are not necessarily happy like Miss Marsalles, talented like Dolores Boyle or immune to treachery like Myra.

Patricia Perry in “The Time of Death” wants to find social acceptance. She plans to become a famous singer when she grows up. She likes to look at movie magazines and magazines with pictures of clothes and rooms in them, and “she likes to look in the windows of some of the houses uptown.” Patricia’s clumsy, misinterpreted attempts to win social approval never get her what she wants, only mark her more distinctly as an outcast. Attempting to clean the place up “like other places,” she boils water as she has seen Mrs. McGee, one of the town’s staunch citizens, do. Unfortunately, the retarded baby, Benny, is scalded to death because of her attempts.

After the death of Benny, the town’s women who come to comfort the “unwashed, unliked and desolate Leona,” mask their feelings of smugness, condescension and hate towards the family, “their faces looming pale and heavy,” hung with the ritual masks of mourning and compassion. They comfort Leona, “in the stately tones of ritualistic soothing.” These women,

hiding behind their rituals do not face the horror of another reality that Patricia does. She represses all natural expression of grief and guilt over Benny's death in her futile attempts to conform to the norm. But her icy composure and concern for social niceties, only further alienates her from the social garrison. At the end of the story Munro externalizes Patricia's vision of an insane reality in the image of the scissors man as madman:

Down the road they heard his unintelligible chant, mournful and shrill and so strange that you would think, if you did not know it was the scissors-man, that there was a madman loose in the world.

(Dance, p. 98)

She stood screaming her hatred of him in the yard "like a wretched little animal insane with rage or fear." The story ends with the snow that came "falling slowly, evenly," symbolically smothering "the dead gardens" and "the wooden houses that had never been painted, with the wood-smoke coming out of their chimneys," with flakes that did not melt "on the hard furrows, the rock of the earth." Like Helen in "Day of The Butterfly" and Maddy in "The Peace of Utrecht," Patricia pays a tremendous price for the repression of natural feelings. The title symbolically suggests it is also "the time of death" spiritually for the women who ritualistically comfort the "unwashed, unliked and desolate Leona"; just as Myra's fatal illness is the externalized representation of the death of Helen's individuality within the garrison.

Munro shows in "The Office," "Images," "Thanks For The Ride," and "Walter Brothers Cowboy" that words are often a verbal mask used to create barriers which protect individuals from confronting the reality of "the other country." Just as Helen in "Day of The Butterfly" wonders, "what lie to tell" to avoid friendship with Myra, the outsider, so too, the writer in "The Office" is met by "the perceptible circles of dismay . . . smoothed out by such ready and tactful voices," when she confesses she writes fiction. In the other stories, silence masks the new found awareness of "the other country."

In "Images," the young protagonist promises her father secrecy about the axe-toting eccentric who lives underground "like an animal" with his

whiskey-drinking cat believing, “what an animal does by and large it makes sense.” When the narrator first encounters this man, she realizes

What hit me did not feel like fear so much as recognition. I was not surprised. This is the sight that does not always surprise you, the thing you have always known was there that comes so naturally, moving delicately, and contentedly, . . . a hope of something final, terrifying.

(*Dance*, p. 38)

Contrasted with this naturalistic image of an inhabitant of “the other country” is her aunt, “implacable,” as “big and gloomy as an iceberg,” who believes, “a man like that ought to be locked up.” Her father recognizing the genuineness of Old Joe hopes, “just the same . . . that they don’t get him for a while yet.” The protagonist realizes she is:

Like the children in fairy stories who have seen their parents make pacts with terrifying strangers, who have discovered that our fears are based on nothing but the truth, but who come back fresh from marvellous escapes and take up their knives and forks with humility and good manners.

(*Dance*, p. 43)

The narrator complies with her father’s request for silence about the encounter, masking the truth of her vision to protect her mother and Aunt Mary who would not understand “the other country” and to protect Old Joe from hassles from “the world.”

In “Thanks For The Ride,” Dick too gets a glimpse into “the other country” when he picks up one of its inhabitants, Lois, who like Patricia Perry, desires to be part of the social norm. The protagonists in Munro’s stories are usually women. “Thanks For The Ride” in *Dance of The Happy Shades* is narrated by Dick; “Walking on Water” in *Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You* features Mr. Loughheed as protagonist. All other stories in these collections feature female protagonists because Munro believes as she explains in an interview with John Metcalf, that there are no writers

who create equally well, male and female characters. She does not think male authors create good female characters; nor do female authors create viable male characters.² At first Dick worries that Lois like other girls intends to make him, “into this caricature of The Date, the boy who grins and shuffles in the front hall and waits to be presented to the nice girl’s family.” He realizes:

Something about this life I had not known, something about these people. I thought my mother, George’s mother, they are innocent. Even George, George is innocent. But these others are born sly and sad and knowing.

(*Dance*, p. 51)

Going out with Lois for “something to do,” Dick seduces Lois ritualistically and without feeling.

I was aware that I should be beyond this, beyond the first stage and well into the second (for I had a knowledge, though it was not very comprehensive, of the orderly progression of stages, the ritual of back- and front-seat seduction)

(*Dance*, p. 53)

Dick’s silence during the drive back to town is torturous to him but he can’t utter the expected phrases, shunning the conventional mask of “the solicitude of friendly voices”

All the things I wanted to say to her went clattering emptily through my head. *Come and see you again — Remember — Love* — I could not say any of those things. They would not seem even half-true across the space that had come between us.

(*Dance*, p. 51)

Arriving at her house, he realizes that his move to kiss her good-night, “had after all been something fraudulent and theatrical.” Lois’ “loud, crude, female voice, abusive and forlorn: ‘Thanks for the ride!’” (*Dance*, p. 58)

yelled at the departing car is a communiqué of another sort from “the other country” in response to Dick’s truthful silence in which (unlike the boys she goes out with in the summer who play the social game) Dick makes no attempt to mask the truth about Lois. In “Images,” “Walker Brothers Cowboy” and “Thanks for the Ride,” a young protagonist becomes aware of the existence and the irreconcilable nature of two realities and masks the truth in silence. In other stories such as “The Office,” “Day of The Butterfly” and “The Peace of Utrecht,” false solicitous words act as a mask because ultimately “Silence disturbs us.” In either situation, however, the result is a sense of isolation and often alienation.

The protagonists in all of these stories in *Dance of The Happy Shades* have a glimpse of “the other country” where “the world proved its absurdity,” peopled by Miss Marsalles, Mrs. Fullerton, Nora Cronin, Joe Phippen, Patricia Perry, Myra Sayla and Lois. The protagonist of a Munro story becomes aware, even though she cannot (or chooses not to) articulate the fact, that a kind of moral chaos governs everything and that one can find nothing tangible or lasting to give security or meaning to life and consequently the protagonist remains aligned with the conventional world of order, ceremony, ritual, social roles and “ready and tactful voices” to derive some sense of meaning from the terrors and contradictions of existence. Munro’s characters can’t really win. To shun the conventional garrison is to face isolation and rejection. To accept “the world” is to live inevitably a paralyzing inauthentic life of half-truths. As the protagonist in “Red Dress — 1946” concludes, “I understood what a mysterious and oppressive obligation I had, to be happy, and how I had almost failed it and would be likely to fail it every time.”

FOOTNOTES

1. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," John Metcalf, *Journal of Canadian Fiction*, 1, No. 4, (Fall, 1972), p. 58
2. *Ibid.*, p. 58

Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You (1974)

“What we say and feel no longer rings true, it is slightly beside the point. As if we were all wound up a long time ago and were spinning out of control, . . . This is a message; I really believe it is; but I don't see how I can deliver it.”

“The Spanish Lady”
p. 153

Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You (1974) moves into a larger, more cosmopolitan world. Only six of the thirteen stories are rooted in what is considered typically Munro country. The other seven have contemporary urban settings that range from Vancouver, Calgary, and the Ottawa Valley. There is also a wider variety of characters, fewer girls and young women and more middle-aged or elderly people. Only "How I Met My Husband" and "The Found Boat" are reminiscent in tone of the innocence with which characters view the two worlds. However, Munro's relentless probing of the nature of reality, continues throughout these stories which Munro compares in the last story, "The Ottawa Valley" to "a series of snapshots, like the brownish snapshots with fancy borders that my parent's old camera used to take" — pictures of characters like Mr. Loughheed in "Walking on Water" trying to understand "the solidity, complexity, reality of those presences" that cause him and others like him to come into contact with "a world of which the world he lived in now seemed the most casual imitation." In *Dance of The Happy Shades*, the protagonists become aware of the paradoxical position in the anomaly of choosing the "true lies" of the conventional world as protection from this other reality. Like the narrator in "The Spanish Lady," Munro's protagonists in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* also believe:

What we say and feel no longer rings true, it is slightly beside the point. As if we were all wound up a long time ago and were spinning out of control.

The protagonists in this book also, to greater degrees than those in *Dance* cope by relying on their "tricks and trap doors" to feign acceptance of, "ritual labours, small rewards of coffee and cigarettes, the desperate, humourous formalized exchanges with other women" or else become involved in, "humiliating charades" with various lovers in order not to face the reality of a world "spinning out of control." When confronted by "proof of reality," protagonists, like the narrator in "The Spanish Lady" decide, "It is terrible when you find out that your idea of reality is not the real reality." Eleven of the fifteen stories in *Dance of the Happy Shades* and every

episode in *Lives of Girls and Women* are told in the first person which perhaps illustrates Munro's concern at the time with the subjective dimensions of reality especially as perceived by youth. However, only seven of the thirteen stories in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* are narrated by the first person, perhaps to reflect Munro's concern expressed by Eugene in "Walking on Water" that external reality is nothing like so fixed as we have been led to believe and that man is "at the mercy" of "methods of control"; reality is not totally subjective. Only half of the stories in *The Moons of Jupiter* are narrated subjectively. *Who Do You Think You Are?* (published in 1978) is narrated entirely in the third person, perhaps reflecting Munro's growing awareness of the objectivity of empirical reality. Unlike those protagonists in *Dance of The Happy Shades* who inadvertently stumble upon the "real reality," paradoxically, the protagonists in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You*, dig, root out of their consciousness truths about reality. However, despite whatever insight into reality each has, each story ends with the protagonist unable or unwilling to communicate what is "true" to others or even to herself, of actually facing her undisguised self. The resultant pattern of "unconsummated relationships" begun in *Dance of The Happy Shades* is central to the readers understanding in all of these stories and in fact unifies the book as a whole. The inability to communicate is implied in the title of the book itself. The vague message suggested by "something" and "meaning" represents the unfulfilled relationships as the "I" means to "tell" (not talk with) "you" but never actually does.

Protagonists in "Material," "Tell Me Yes or No," and "The Ottawa Valley" typical of Munro's protagonists actually inhibit communication by hiding in a metaphorical "bag of tricks." In "Material," the narrator realizes that people are fascinated by men like her former husband, typical of writers, who "work daringly out in the public eye without the protection of any special discipline" in contrast to themselves who are "just trying to trust themselves and elaborating their bag of tricks and hoping to catch on." Admiring a story written by Hugo about a former neighbour, she sees that he has used, "lovely tricks, honest tricks" to lift Dotty their former neighbour out of life and into Art. She categorizes Hugo as a man typical of those who have decided, "what to do about everything they run across in this world, what attitude to take, how to ignore things or use things. They

are not at the mercy or think they are not.” The protagonist feels “at the mercy” and consequently cannot ultimately write the congratulatory letter to Hugo that she was “meaning” to because what she wants “to tell” him is actually “something” else. She is typical of most of Munro’s protagonists who find themselves in ambivalent and unresolved positions in these stories. She envies and despises him; even though she says she cannot blame men like Hugo, “for making whatever arrangements they can make” she knows,

how shopworn and simple really are the disguises, the identities if you like, that people take up. In fiction, in Hugo’s business, such disguises would not do, but in life they are all we seem to want, all anybody can manage.

(*Something*, p. 24)

In “Tell Me Yes or No,” the narrator grapples after the death of her lover with the authenticity of this past love affair, “a love of limits,” in which she now sees her main concerns were “how to disguise love, to make it harmless and merry.” Then, she could not understand his lazy, indifferent attitude to his own aging, believing it to be “a pose.” She realizes after his death that, “what I could not credit, did not have the imagination to credit” was that the “pose,” “might be real.” She had been unable then to see, or face his reality, remarking that then, she “refused . . . to see you as you seemed to see yourself.” Visiting his home town after his death, she is confronted by the truth, not only about him and his other love, but also about herself. Like other women, she has built her castles, “on foundations hardly strong enough to support a night’s shelter.” Visiting the bookstore where his wife works, the narrator is given a pack of love letters that the wife mistakenly believes have been sent by the narrator. Reading these letters addressed to her lover, from a woman who does not know of his death, makes her realize that this woman also, “suffers according to rules we all know, which are meaningless and absolute.” The experience forces her to touch on a painful truth: that their relationship was perhaps for him, “a strange, not even pitiable, expenditure; an unintelligible ceremony.”

Unwilling in the end to bear the implications of love being only an expenditure she concludes:

I invented you as far as my purposes go. I invented loving you and I invented your death. I have my tricks and my trap doors too. I don't understand their workings at the present moment but I have to be careful, I won't speak against them.

(*Something*, p. 101)

Other stories conclude in the same manner, after the protagonist through painful introspection of past memories uncovers unpalatable truths only to retreat behind the safety of disguises or tricks and trap doors. In "The Ottawa Valley," the narrator visits Aunt Dodie, clearly an inhabitant of Munro's "other country" who wears men's clothing, used the word "bugger," and who lives "in the poorest house" the narrator had ever been in. Contrasted to Aunt Dodie is Aunt Lena on the next farm, typifying "the world," who "was stiff all the time with what I now recognize as terror" her children "were all liars, even the little ones, brilliant, instinctive liars who lied even when it was not necessary, just for the practice, and maybe the pleasure of it."

Contrasted to Lena's concealment and her family's "lies," is Dodie's good humoured openness about the tragedy of her life — the day she was jilted at the church. She also talks freely about her role in her own mother's death; while noting that this story makes the young narrator cry, she says, "Well you are a baby, if you can't stand to hear about Life." As a child, the narrator felt her aunt was "like a gypsy woman flashing malice and kindness at me, threatening to let out more secrets than I could stand." Unlike Aunt Dodie who is not afraid of life, the narrator in later life, trying to understand her mother's illness and her own guilt feelings, realizes that despite the fact that she "wanted to find out more, remember more. I wanted to bring back all I could" ultimately she can't face her guilt, and can only go on, "applying what skills I have, using what tricks I know," in order to cope. Many of the stories in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* show Munro's protagonists like the narrators in "Material" and "Tell Me Yes or No," finding themselves in an anomalous position like the narrator in "The

Ottawa Valley,” desirous of, but unable to attain the naturalism of an Aunt Dodie yet not as terror stricken or closed as an Aunt Lena.

Many characters in these stories, like the narrators in “Ottawa Valley,” “Tell Me Yes or No” and “Material,” are trying to put past memories into the perspective of present reality. Munro’s stories characteristically shift to flashbacks, with the past often occupying the central position in the story, and flashforwards, always ending with the present reality, with her characters unable to reconcile reality on different time levels. Munro explains that at one point in her rewriting she worried that she was shifting time too much; “it’s too repetitive” but decided finally that the information given in this technique is more important than a neat story because “the past is important for the way it shapes the present.” At one point she cut all the retrospects in *Who Do You Think You Are?* and while “the immediacy” was better, she put the retrospects back in.¹

The elderly Mr. Lougheed in “Walking on Water” makes a concerted effort to understand, “how to convey the solidity, complexity, reality of those presences” — his memories of his parents and the dreams of his childhood. He grapples with the idea that his recurring dream of the floating body of Frank McArter, “had brought him in touch with a world of which the world he lived in now seemed the most casual imitation.” He never finishes the dream and is unsure if the dream is a reflection of what really happened or is only a dream; because everyone in the dream is dead, he has no way of verifying reality. Through Eugene who is recovering from a recent mental breakdown, he tries to comprehend and verify the possibilities of another reality while still believing that, it had to be a trick and that Eugene was going to make a fool of himself in his attempts to walk on water. Eugene is unable to walk on the water and when Eugene disappears after his failure to control the laws of gravity, Mr. Lougheed becomes frantic in his futile search for Eugene who represents for Lougheed another reality that could validate his own vision of reality. However, Eugene has disappeared without a trace. He believes at the end that perhaps after all, “there was something to be said for dealing with things the way most people of his age seemed to.” Sadly, perhaps because of despair, “. . . of being at the end of the track,” he realizes, for the first time he might not be able to get to the top of the stairs. He doubts his powers even for that. Giving up his search for another reality, he concludes

by feeling that he will have to go into an apartment building, “like the rest of them if he wanted to continue.”

Eugene, the eccentric, the outsider of Munro’s “other country,” points out the essential lie about the conventional world to Mr. Lougheed, the conventional character who desires, “to give people what they thought they wanted.” He tells Lougheed:

The world that we accept — you know, external reality . . . is nothing like so fixed as we have been led to believe. It responds to more methods of control that we are conditioned to accept.

(*Something*, p. 61)

Munro’s protagonists in *Dance of The Happy Shades* are aware of words that are “half-true” and the “ready and tactful voices” and “things that are not to be mentioned” or “kept in the dark.” *Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You* makes more strident use of the lie as verbal mask. Ten of the thirteen stories in this book consider the degree to which the protagonists live with lies as masks, facilitating conformity to the world of convention. The narrator in “The Spanish Lady” wonders when she learns about her husband’s affair, “why it is a surprise to find that people other than ourselves are able to tell lies.” She admits to herself that, “I have lied as well as I have been lied to.” She, too, has had secretive affairs. No wonder she concludes that, “what we say and feel no longer rings true.” In “Marrakesh,” Dorothy wonders if the whole story is made up that her grand-daughter tells Blair King. She feels in the story that something here is not being told because as a former teacher, “she had a great deal of experience listening to the voices of children who were leaving things out.” In “Memorial,” June, seeking social acceptance often told, “a long, melancholy, garbled and untrue story about how their family was related to Arthur Meighen.” Munro points out that, “she was learning by leaps and bounds the language that would serve her well for the rest of her life.” In contrast, Eileen, her unconventional sister, realizes that the words read from *The Prophet* at the Memorial Service for June’s son are “such fraud,” and a kind of lie because the emotions are not genuine. “No fraud in the words but what fraud now in saying them.” Like Dick in “Thanks For The Ride,”

Eileen realizes that, “silence is the only possible thing.” Reading the dust-jacket on Hugo’s new book, his ex-wife in “Material” is aware of the distortions and omissions made about his reality in order to present him as a more saleable commodity. The details she reads are, “the lies, the half-lies, the absurdities,” and that these lies are “the disguises, the identities . . . that people take up.” The lie told by Et in “Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You,” proves to have fatal results. Et loves her sister’s husband despite her belief that he is just an ostrich hiding his head in the safe vision of the acceptable. “He did not know why things happened, why people could not behave sensibly. He was too good. He knew about history but not about what went on in front of his eyes in his house, anywhere.” Finally, to thwart Char’s passion for her lover, Et lies about his marriage and while she had not planned it, “it came so easily, believably.” Char poisons herself and Et, smuggly inside the cloak of respectability, is left keeper of Char’s “good” husband. If they had been married, people would have said they were very happy and although she has, “on the tip of her tongue to say to Arthur, ‘There’s something I’ve been meaning to tell you’,” she, “let it go, day by day.”

“Winter Wind,” “Executioners,” and “Memorial” show the extent to which, by repression of natural feelings, and acquiescence of conventional norms, characters’ lives are in fact fraudulent lies. “Winter Wind” typifies Munro’s two worlds. Her grandmother’s house where, “they ironed everything, down to underwear and pot-holders” contrasts with the narrator’s home where, “dirt and chaos threatened all the time.” The protagonist falsifies reports of her mother’s actual bad condition in her progressive, incurable disease, so that her grandmother might not learn, “how disastrously we fell short of that ideal of order and cleanliness, household decency, which I as much as anyone else believed in.” Some of her mother’s creative ideas like painting decorations on the doors of the cupboards (instead of cooking dinner or doing the mending) clash with the values of the grandmother who believes that, “houses should be made to look as much as possible like other people’s houses.” At first the narrator sees, “the sense in this conformity.” However, after staying three days with her grandmother in town during a winter storm, she yearns to return home, “to confusion and necessity.” The story of the freezing death of Suzie Heferman is used by Munro as an externalization of the grandmother’s

internal freezing of her emotions and desires. Seeing her grandmother weeping furiously over the death of Susie Heferman, and “also for herself,” the narrator realizes the awful price to be paid in conformity by people like her grandmother who had, “schooled herself, watched herself, learned what to do and say; she had understood the importance of acceptance, had yearned for it, had achieved it.” She once, “so baffled and struggling, had become another old woman whom people deceived and placated and were anxious to get away from.”

The narrator in “Executioners” also wanted conformity at all costs and finds a price to be paid for repression of feelings. She tries continuously to anaesthetize, by social acceptance and finally by alcohol, the truth of her own emotions. The aging alcoholic woman who sits alone in the dark drinking whiskey and water, thinking uselessly and helplessly almost comfortably about things she could not bear to think about for a long time. She reminisces about her unpleasant memories, “running underground . . . spurting out at another place in her mind,” in which as a child, she has been an accessory in spirit to the actual executioners who set the bootlegger’s house ablaze killing both he and the lewd son who used to taunt her. At home, as a child, she felt like an outsider because of her mother’s prideful values and her father’s drinking. Once she went off to college she believed she could turn out like anybody else and indeed Robina, another outsider, observes that the narrator, “had become one of those people.” Now, like the lonely old woman in “Winter Wind,” she pays the price of conformity sitting alone, in the dark, drinking, tormented by past repressed feelings.

Just as “Winter Wind” contrasted order and chaos, so too “Memorial” contrasts Munro’s two visions of reality. While the grandmother conformed to an old set of norms, the characters in “Memorial” have adopted a new set of equally unnatural rituals and disguises with equally fraudulent results. Eileen has come to visit her younger sister, June, for the memorial service for their son who has had a tragic accident. Eileen who lives “irresponsibly” represented chaos; June, in her, “eagerness, bossiness, busyness” represents, “some lively insistence on control.” “While Eileen’s life took shape any way at all, blown apart by crisis, deflected by pleasures, June’s life was built, planned, lived deliberately filled.”

Eileen finds herself becoming paralyzed by the conforming couples at the house and by the stifling atmosphere of her sister's unemotional rationalizations. Getting progressively drunker, she sees that, "the only thing we can hope for is that we lapse now and then into reality," and that reality is that, "people die; they suffer, they die . . . illness and accidents. They ought to be respected, not explained." Later that night, she allows Ewart, her brother-in-law, to seduce her. She thinks that for him she is "aimless, and irresponsible; she comes out of the same part of the world accidents come from. He lies in her to acknowledge, to yield — but temporarily, safely — to whatever has got his son." The next morning as June tells Eileen the truth about her son's death, of how the car fell on him, Eileen sees her own face in the mirror, assume a mask, "with its wonderfully appropriate look of tactfulness and concern." In reality, despite her wish "to avoid fraud":

she mostly wanted to get away. It was an effort to put her hand out. Acts done without faith may restore faith. She believed with whatever energy she could summon at that moment, she had to believe and hope that was true.

(*Something*, p. 181)

June is a younger and in some ways a more horrifying version of the grandmother in "Winter Wind" whom "people deceived and placated and were anxious to get away from." The grandmother mistakenly trusted Victorian norms of "self-denying passion, never satisfied, never risked." However, June's lack of passion, "her modern equivalent of piety" and sense of responsibility to society come from choice. For a while she had some vague idea of fashioning herself after older sister, instead she conformed to the sterile values of "the world." Just as "The Time of Death" in *Dance of The Happy Shades* symbolically alludes to the spiritual deaths caused by conformity so too the Memorial Service attests to the spiritual deaths of naturalism in characters like June who are protected from Eileen's vision of reality by her rigid conformity to order.

Paradox helps sustain Munro's thematic insistence of the doubleness of reality. Because Munro's vision insists on the doubleness of reality, it is not

surprising that paradox becomes one of Munro's most important techniques. Often Munro's descriptions of her characters entail incongruities. A housewife finds herself "sheltered and encumbered, warmed and bound by her home"; a maiden aunt stumbling on her niece and lover naked and passionate perceives them as "strange and familiar, both more and less than themselves." A character's feelings for her relatives are described as "irritable . . . bonds of sympathy." In these instances Munro uses an oxymoron, most often in the form of two parallel but incompatible verbs or adjectives. The startling fusion of discordant qualities gives a denseness and precision characteristic of poetry. Because she uses the conjunction "and," disregarding conjunctions of limitation, the contradictory emotions retain their individual intensity. In her examination of human inconsistency, Munro presents the contradictions not only within emotions but also between emotion and behaviour. Paradox for Alice Munro in "Memorial" as in these other stories, reflects her vision of the complexity of human emotion and of the human situation generally. The protagonists like Eileen see another reality but do not fully comprehend it and often feel as Eileen does that even though she has "a wish to avoid fraud, not to appropriate serious things for trivial uses, not to mock things by making them into fashions. A doomed wish. She herself offended." Despite the fact that she believes that now and then she lapses into reality and that men with whom she has sex "— realized their lovely devout and naked seriousness, attention to realities, their own realities," later she wonders, "if that is not all literary, fanciful." In the end she can only "hope" and "believe" that what she feels is so. In "Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You," Et is disgruntled to discover her sister, bad tempered, is at the same time classically beautiful, "that the qualities of legend were real, that they surfaced where and when you least expected." Et's disgruntlement occurs because she dislikes things out of place; the implication is that she is rejecting reality which Munro typifies as inherently contradictory. The narrator in "Material" who feels that her present husband, Gabe, seeks "a plausible connection, a proof of reality" through her, nevertheless is confused at the end by her ambivalent feelings toward Hugo, noting that her unfinished letter to him contains, "short, jabbing sentences that I had never planned." She pretends to Gabe who notices her mood that she is "not unhappy but preoccupied." In Munro's fiction there is often little attempt to

reduce the inconsistency or explain why actions defy their motivations; the two conflicting realities are simply juxtaposed.

In “Spanish Lady,” the narrator who grapples throughout the story with her two conflicting realities trying to put the affair between her husband and best friend into the perspective of “the real reality,” must at the end, try to reconcile the old man’s death at the train station into the scheme of reality. “Some people continue with their baggage as if not a thing has happened and none of the other old men sitting on the bench had risen; in fact they hardly look at him.” She concludes:

What we say and feel no longer rings true, it is slightly beside the point. As if we were all wound up a long time ago and were spinning out of control, . . . This is a message; I really believe it is; but I don’t see how I can deliver it.

(*Something*, p. 153)

In all of these stories these visions, inherently coherent and explicitly identified as independent worlds, in most cases vie with each other for the exclusive right to define experience. In the end, none has ultimate authority; each is clearly presented as one reality in the context of the other. Consequently, Munro’s protagonists are doomed to fail, because they try to define their own existences through one reality at the expense of the other, failing to see, “a whole dense vision of the world.”

In *Dance of The Happy Shades*, Munro shows a distinct division between two worlds, her two realities. Her protagonists, safely protected by the norms of “the world” get a glimpse through a communiqué of sorts of “the marvellous shattering absurdity” of “the other country.” No outright commitment to either value system is required in most of the stories, although some — like “The Peace of Utrecht” — do suggest the emotional turmoil of the next book. The stories in *Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You*, show the same divided universe, but the distinction between the two worlds blurs, as it becomes evident that one can’t live entirely in one reality. The realities juxtapose in a grey area where the protagonist often finds herself, sorting out past memories in a painful introspective process that seeks “proof of reality.” In “Memorial,” Eileen realizes that the funeral

is a ritualistic occasion, “to display, to air, to test those values that we live by.” All the protagonists must in fact, test these values, and ultimately the protagonists make a conscious choice for the safety of the conventional world because of the fear of the disintegration of self. A few like Eileen ponder if, “indeed there are any choices” or like the narrator in “The Spanish Lady” believe, “we were all wound up a long time ago” and hence lack free will. These protagonists prefigure Rose in *Who Do You Think You Are?* who has the ability, unlike the others, “to see too many sides of things,” presented in a fictional world of even greater ambiguity, where reality is harder to define than in the previous three collections and hence the questioning title.

FOOTNOTES

1. Alice Munro, “*Who Do You Think You Are?* Review-Interview with Alice Munro,” *Room of One’s Own*, 4, No. 4, (1979), p. 6

Lives of Girls and Women (1971)

“Now at last without fantasies or self-deception, cut off from the mistakes and confusion of the past, grave and simple, carrying a small suitcase, getting on a bus, like girls in movies leaving home, convents, lovers, I supposed I would get started on my real life.”

“Baptizing”
p. 201

Lives of Girls and Women (1971) has been called variously memoir, autobiography, novel, and collection of short stories. Munro believes that *Lives of Girls and Women* is a novel because the sections, while inter-linked by having the same character throughout, are with the exception of two, not self-contained units that can stand completely on their own. (However, one story, “Baptizing,” was successfully dramatized by the CBC in 1978, featuring Munro’s daughter Jenny in the role of Del.) She also feels that the sections are too long, too diffuse and too lacking in an essential tension to be classified as short stories. Munro told John Metcalf “I am essentially a short story writer. That is why any novel I write will be said in some quarters to be short stories.”¹ However, in an interview with Graham Gibson in *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, Munro states:

. . .some people say, of course, *Lives* is only a collection of long short stories. This doesn’t particularly bother me, because I don’t feel that a novel is any step up from a short story. When I began to write *Lives*, you see, I began to write it as a much more, a much looser novel, with all these things going on at the same time, and it wasn’t working. Then I began pulling the material and making it into what are almost self-contained segments. I mean the sections could almost stand as short stories. They’re all a little bit loose, but this seemed to be the only way I could work and I think maybe this is the way I’ll have to write books. I write sort of on — like a single string, a tension string — okay? That’s the segment or the story. I don’t write as perhaps as some people say a true novelist does, manipulating a lot of strings.²

While there are many similarities between *Lives of Girls and Women* and *Who Do You Think You Are?* — single protagonists, carried through in a sequence of episodic, linked stories in a bildungsroman tradition, with each book culminating in an epilogue story, nevertheless, Munro sees *Lives* as a novel and *Who* as linked stories, because *Lives* explains enough for that period of Del’s life whereas *Who* doesn’t work as a novel because it doesn’t explain enough.³

Despite Munro's disclaimer in the book that "This novel is autobiographical in form but not in fact. My family, neighbours and friends did not serve as models," she explains that *Lives*:

could be called an autobiographical novel . . . most of the incidents are changed versions of real incidents. Some are completely invented, but emotional reality, the girl's feelings for her mother, for men, for all is all . . . it's all solidly autobiographical. I would not disclaim this at all.⁴

Munro's story is told by Del who reflects back with the maturity of hindsight, on her growth from childhood to adolescence in the 1930s and 40s in Munro's fictional town of Jubilee, the mythical setting of some of Munro's stories in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You*. There are fragments of high school trivia, visits with eccentric relatives, adolescent fantasies and romances. The short story as Munro writes it is a deliberate fragment with the story line more like rambling reminiscing with various anecdotes about characters and events, worked around a central incident such as Uncle Benny's marriage in "The Flats Road" or the funeral in "Heirs of the Living Body." Unlike chapters in a conventional novel, the narration in these linked stories breaks off at the end of each; we are never told whether Major is actually shot, or even how the visit with Bobby ends, but that is not what matters. What is of concern is the epiphany, the "seeing" by the narrator and in turn the reader of truths about "real life" in each of the seven segments.

Lives, typical of all of Munro's writing, sets out to investigate the nature of reality; *Real Life* was in fact the original title intended for the book. Munro, through Del's narration, wants to capture, "every last thing, every layer of speech and thought, stroke of light on bark, or walls; every smell, pothole, pain, crack, delusion held still, and held together — radiant, everlasting," because as Munro says, "the thing I most want to do is look at things and see the way everything is."⁵

Del Jordan's growth, besides being an examination of contrasting options available to women, is an exploration of perceived realities. A series of self-contained, often mutually exclusive words are played against each other: Uncle Benny's naturalistic world along the Wawanash River: the "tiny

sealed off countries” of Aunts Elspeth and Grace; Ida Jordan’s intellectual, socially naïve world beyond the social garrison; the social clique of Naomi and the working girls. Throughout the book Del struggles against the paradoxical and disparate worlds and the dichotomy of selves that she envisages, in conflict constantly between self and soul, mask and will. The resolution of this conflict ultimately transforms her and gives her character its dynamic quality, enabling her to free herself from Garnet French and Jubilee, to move on assertively to “real life.”

Del’s ambivalent position in relationship with the different worlds is symbolized through the name that Munro gives her. Jordan is a river in Palestine, the one the Israelites cross into the promised land and the one where John the Baptist does his baptizing and “dell,” a small deep valley; a hollow. Also, the duality in Del’s nature is suggested by the irony in her position as the faith seeking daughter of Ida, the agnostic daughter of a religious fanatic, described by Ida in various “demented stages of Christianity.” It is no coincidence that the turning point of the book and Del’s epiphany occurs during the baptizing episode. Munro also uses the geographical settings of the book as an externalization of Del’s position. The Jordans live outside town on The Flats Road,⁶ a no-man’s land that is “not part of town . . . not part of the country either.” This is Munro’s “other country” where various eccentrics, bootleggers and idiots live. Ida Jordan by nature of her eccentricities will not be accepted by the social garrison in town, nevertheless she cannot accept relegation to “the other country” with its “sexually looseness, dirty language, haphazard lives, contented ignorance” and her walks to town represent her desperate futile struggle to be of “the world.”

The Flats Road was the last place my mother wanted to live. As soon as her feet touched the town sidewalk and she raised her head, grateful for town shade after Flat Roads sun, a sense of relief, a new sense of consequence flowed from her.

(Lives, p. 6)

Eventually Ida moves the family into town (although, “later on she was to find she did not belong in Jubilee either”) to a house on River Road with its

symbolic connotations of mobility. Del is torn between the two worlds. In town she reminisces about the old house “with a forlorn, faintly guilty, tender pain” missing the nearness of the river and the swamp, “the real anarchy of winter blizzards that shut us up tight in our house,” “the order, the wholeness, the intricate arrangement of town life.” Del’s father spent weekends in town, returning weekly to the fox farm and Uncle Benny’s world because unlike his wife

He felt comfortable here, while with men from town, with any man who wore a shirt and tie to work, he could not help being wary, a little proud and apprehensive of insult, with that delicate, special readiness to scent pretention that is some country people’s talent . . . Flats Road would do for him.

(Lives, p. 7)

Eventually, her father, her brother Owen and Uncle Benny stay permanently on Flats Road.

Chief among the eccentrics of this symbolic “other country” is Uncle Benny, “the sort of man who becomes a steadfast eccentric almost before he is out of his teens.” Like many of Munro’s eccentrics, Uncle Benny has gifts denied to inhabitants of “the world.” The most important of these is passion, the ability to feel strongly and spontaneously:

In all his statements, predictions, judgements there was a concentrated passion. In our yard, once, looking up at a rainbow, he cried, “You know what that is? That’s the Lord’s promise that there isn’t ever going to be another flood.” He quivered with the momentousness of this promise as if it had just been made and he himself was the bearer of it.

(Lives, p. 2)

Del recognizes that Uncle Benny’s world, “was like a troubling distorted reflection” of the world, “the same, but never at all the same . . . nothing was deserved, anything might happen”; yet she is a half-way character between her mother and father’s worlds, typical of Munro’s protagonists

who recognize the freedom and naturalism of “the other country” yet aspire to the social garrison. “I myself was not so different from my mother, but concealed it, knowing what dangers there were,” Del reports. Later in the book Del is offered “perfect security” and love from Garnet French, another character who lives significantly outside of town on a farm inhabiting a world “dense and complicated but appallingly unsecretive,” a world not far from what she thought animals must see. Despite the fact that there is no denying she was happy in his house, she rejects his offer for marriage. Earlier her mother had warned her she

had gone addled over a boy. You with your intelligence. Do you intend to live in Jubilee all your life? Do you want to be the wife of a lumberyard worker? Do you want to join the Baptist Ladies Aid?

(Lives, p. 183)

Del’s answer is obviously, “no.” The book ends with Del going out into the world, aware later that her attitude toward everything her mother said had become one of skepticism and disdain because Del feels “probably closer to the truth than she was.” Consequently the reader can discern a symbolic physical movement related to the book’s geographical detail that unifies the structure of the entire book and parallels Del’s growing awareness.

From her anomalous position, Del observes the lives of girls and women in the context of these worlds. The lives of men, such as her father, Uncle Benny, and Owen fade into the background as the narrative progresses. Munro says originally she didn’t tend to do this:

. . .but I found that my emphasis, my interest was shifting so much to the mother that I had to be able to deal with her alone. I couldn’t deal with both parents. I have a fairly narrow focus or something so the father tended to sort of fade away.⁷

Other men — Mr. Chamberlain, Frank Wales, Jerry Storey, Garnet French are presented through a limited female vision as they affect the lives of girls and women in the book. Munro says she doesn’t try to make “real characters” out of men but instead she makes “the appearance character, the

way the woman sees them.”⁸ Munro, however, gives women’s lives full scope and range delving into the intimate detail of women’s relationships and understanding with each other, with men and with their inner selves through the vehicle of Del’s narrated perceptions of such women as her mother, Aunts Elspeth, Moira and Grace, her best friend Naomi, Miss Farris — the grade 3 teacher, and Fern Dogherty — her mother’s boarder.

Auntie Grace and Aunt Elspeth’s, the two maiden aunts, lives revolve around being dutiful, self-sacrificing; their homes become “tiny sealed off countries” where honesty, intellect and overt sexuality are forbidden. Instead these women, like Aunt Lou and Aunt Annie in “The Peace of Utrecht” live an ordered life of intricate domestic and private social ritual, of elaborate verbal games or childish pranks. Del sees this traditional passive role supporting a grotesque masquerade made clear to her after Uncle Craig’s death when their lives become ones of stagnant disorientation:

They told the same stories, they played their same jokes, which now seemed dried out, brittle with use; in time every word, every expression of the face, every flutter of the hands came to seem something learned long ago, perfectly remembered, and each of their two selves was seen to be something constructed with terrible care; the older they got, the more frail and admirable and inhuman the construction appeared. This was what became of them when they no longer had a man with them, to nourish and admire, and when they were removed from the place where their artificiality bloomed naturally.

(Lives, p. 50)

Munro externalizes the spiritual decay of the two aunts in the picture of physical decay presented of the married Aunt Moira who wore “some stately layered dress, dark and trembling with beads, a large hat like a turban, with colored stockings which she would sometimes roll down to let the bandages ‘breathe.’ Even getting up or sitting down in the rocker caused Aunt Moira to give off “rumbles of complaint, involuntary and eloquent as noises of digestion or wind.” Del decides “not much could be said for

marriage, really, if you were to compare her to her sisters who could still jump up so quickly.”

When her aunt’s criticized her mother, a woman whose qualities of “sharpness, smartness, determination, selectiveness” Del admires, for “going on the road” selling encyclopedias, Del finds herself in an ambivalent position feeling “the weight of my mother’s eccentricities, of something absurd and embarrassing about her” and she would want “to repudiate her, crawl into favour, orphaned” at the same time she wanted to “shield her” from the two old aunts. Del finds she shares her mother’s appetite for learning and independent thinking but realizes with her awakening sexuality that her mother had “a gloom that overcame her in the vicinity of sex” and that her mother eventually “inhabited a different layer of reality” from hers. Nevertheless Ida’s advice to Del in *Lives of Girls and Women* is central to Del’s epiphany; later in “Baptizing” she tells Del:

there is a change coming I think in the lives of girls and women. Yes. But it is up to us to make it come. All women have had up till now has been their connection with men. All we have had. No more lives of our own, really, than domestic animals. . . . Use your brains. Don’t be distracted. Once you make that mistake of being — distracted, over a man, your life will never be your own.

(*Lives*, p. 146)

At the time, Del initially rejects her advice feeling she “would have had to resist anything she told me with such earnestness, such stubborn hopefulness.” Del also feels that this is not so different from all the other advice handed out to women, to girls:

advice that assumed being female made you damageable, that a certain amount of carefulness and solemn fuss and self-protection were called for, whereas men were supposed to be able to go out and take on all kinds of experiences and shuck off what they didn’t want and come back proud.

(*Lives*, p. 147)

Del says she had “decided to do the same.”

Del has many examples in the lives of girls and women that she observes whose traditional dependence on men has made them “damageable.” Miss Farris, the grade 3 teacher, is a pathetically artificial character “dry and wooden and innocent,” “trying to catch a man” in her dark blue velvet skating costume which she made herself. However, it did not work. Every year there was a hypothetical romance or scandal built up between her and Mr. Boyce but “all baroque concoctions of rumour crumbled, when you looked into her face, her little sharp-boned face, self-consciously rouged and animated, with flickering commas at the corners of her mouth, bright startled eyes.” Her stilted life is externalized in Munro’s description of her doll-like house, almost like a playhouse or a house in a movie, “houses which set out to be charming, whimsical, which looked as if they were designed for play, not life.” Eventually, she purportedly commits suicide by walking into the Wawanash River. Perhaps only by death in the river can she find freedom from her artificial and lonely life.

Fern Dogherty, Ida’s boarder, had in contrast to Miss Farris “a roguish sensual look” and wore a ruby-coloured satin dressing gown, that parted at the knees to show a pale clinging rayon nightgown. She had studied singing at the Royal Conservatory of Music and when she sang “the force, the seriousness of her singing voice, always came as a surprise. It didn’t embarrass her, letting loose those grand, inflated emotions she paid no attention to in life.” However, she didn’t succeed as a singer because she preferred having “a good time” with men. Despite Ida’s claims that Fern’s relationship with Mr. Chamberlain is platonic, Mr. Chamberlain had proposed marriage at one time; after Art Chamberlain suddenly leaves town Fern is disconsolate after being jilted despite her insistence that she wasn’t “in danger of marriage,” and that “men always went, and better they did before you got sick of them.” She becomes very talkative after that and put on weight so that now she was “really fat, swollen up like a boiled pudding, her splotched skin not shady any more but stretched and shiny.”

After Del’s best friend, Naomi, left school and became a working girl, she had become part of a circle of working girls, preoccupied with their hope chests, going from store to store on Saturdays to make payments on their lay-away linens and pots and pans, and planning wedding and baby showers for each other:

Their relations with each other, though full of scandalous confidences, were yet hedged with all kinds of subtle formalities, courtesies, proprieties . . . They were tolerant of what most people in town would think of as moral lapses in each other, but quite tolerant of departure in dress and hair style and people not cutting the crusts off sandwiches, at showers.

(*Lives*, p. 151)

She and all these other girls were firmly set up towards marriage; older women who had not married, like Fern, were regarded as “a joke.” When Del asks why Fern is “a joke,” Naomi just “opened her pale, bright, protruding eyes and repeated, ‘a joke, she was just a joke’ like someone dispensing, in the face of fumbling heresies, self-evident handsome pieces of dogma.” Months later, Naomi dejectedly tells Del of her upcoming marriage to Scott Geoghagen, a lineman for Bell Telephone, whom she has been dating for four months; she is pregnant and feels she “might as well get married”; besides, she has “collected all this stuff.”

So Del has before her these varied examples of women whose lives with their “connections with men,” made “damageable.” Nevertheless, she did not want to be like her mother “with her virginal brusqueness, her innocence.” She wanted men to love her. She became upset after reading an article in a magazine, on the subject of the basic difference between the male and female habits of thought relating chiefly to the experience of sex. The author, a famous New York psychiatrist, claimed that when a boy looks at the moon he thinks of “the universe, its immensity and the mystery” and the girl thinks “I must wash my hair.” She knew the moon would never remind her to wash her hair and “felt trapped, stranded; it seemed there had to be a choice where there couldn’t be a choice.” She tried to be like the well-groomed girlfriends of Naomi who talked about their diets, skin-care routines, hair shampooing methods, clothes, and who always talked about washing, either washing their sweaters, or washing their underclothes or washing their hair. However, Del in her grubby sweater, greasy hair and discoloured brassiere; one strap held on with a safety pin felt incapable of sustained attention to such niceties. Sometimes, Del would wash her hair

and do it up on steel curlers that prevented her from sleeping and then sit in front of a mirror, painfully plucking her eyebrows, looking at her profile, shading her face with dark and light powders to emphasize its good points and minimize the bad as recommended in magazines, believing she would have to learn “to be soft and pink” if she was to get love.

Munro’s development of female character is never far from the persistent reality of their physical bodies. Women’s bodies changed and marked by childbirth, fat, grimy skin, the smells of hair and breath and sweat are as much a definition of the characters as their thoughts, their beliefs and their interactions. This is particularly true in Munro’s exploration of how women come to terms with themselves as physical beings, their sexuality and their relations to men. Munro says:

I know we are forced into this thing where we try to see our bodies through men’s eyes and there’s this terrific concern if the body isn’t acceptable by whatever standards are being presented to us, and I suppose that amounts to a contempt for our individual bodies.⁹

Del is always aware of her body. She loves books where “the heroines generous proportions were tenderly, erotically described,” while she worries about being fat, aware that the insides of her thighs quivered like “cottage cheese in a transparent sack.” After watching Mr. Chamberlain’s masturbation, “his valedictory address,” Del feels “people take along a good deal — flesh that is not overcome but has to be thumped into ecstasy, here too though among the realities people take along are all the stubborn puzzle and dark turns of themselves.” It is this understanding of the reality of the human body that is the key to her final view of her relationship with Garnet French: she knows that their attraction is what is spoken of as “only sex” or “physical attraction,” and when she thought about it she is surprised even years later, “at the light, even disparaging tone that is taken, as if this was something that could be found easily, every day.” This acknowledgement which many women deny, permits Del to eventually resist Garnet’s attempts to move the relationship to another level in the final baptizing scene.

Garnet has seen the true nature of their relationship and its limitations but he tries to deny it, to move beyond it by controlling Del in marriage or as

she realizes in the water, by possibly drowning her. In doing so, he destroys a self: his part as a golden, playful lover. Munro says:

with the Garnet French type you have to escape him as the girl does in the baptizing scene or you literally knuckle under. He presents you with this clear-cut choice, where in a way, the girl works against the promptings of her body and gets out; and it's very difficult for women to make this choice.¹⁰

Munro does not deny that women suffer, that women are vulnerable, but her women have a sense of strength and power that has to do directly with the fact that they do not deny any part of their experience or reject any part of themselves. The epiphany occurs as Del realizes that she has “successfully hid from him” what she was like, just as she took just what she needed of his character, “the dark side, the strange side of him,” paying attention only “to the life of his instincts, never to his ideas.” She had never really wanted his secrets or his violence or himself taken out of the context of that “peculiar and magical” game. In much the same way, Del was careful not to let Jerry Storey, the intellectual, know that at heart she rejected him feeling “powerful enough where his ways of judging could not reach.” She did not admire the gymnastics of his mind, “for people only admire abilities similar to, though greater than, their own.” His mind was “like a circus tent full of dim apparatus on which he performed stunts which were spectacular and boring.” She realizes that Jerry in contrast is truthful in telling her what he thought about her but she had no intention of being truthful to Jerry and later to Garnet because:

I felt in him what women feel in men, something so tender, swollen, tyrannical, absurd; I would never take the consequences of interfering with it: I had an indifference, a contempt almost;

(*Lives*, p. 163)

Fighting in the water later with Garnet she realizes for the first time it was a mistake for anyone to think he could have power over her.

It seemed to me impossible that he should not understand that all the powers I granted him were in play, that he himself was — in play, that I meant to keep him served up in his golden lover's skin forever, even if five minutes before I had talked about marrying him. This was clear as day to me and I opened my mouth to say whatever would make it clear to him and I saw that he knew it all already; this was what he knew, that I had somehow met his good offerings with my deceitful offerings whether I knew it or not, matching my complexity and play acting to his true intent.

Just as the intellectually cold rational world of her mother and Jerry Storey was not enough, so too the physical dark side of Garnet French is not sufficient. The insufficiency of these worlds lies in their total disregard for each other and life's complexity. Even though she entertained for many years the possibility of "the bounty of my lover's body," she knows that:

the future could be furnished without love or scholarships. Now at last without fantasies or self-deception cut off from the mistakes and confusion of the past, grave and simple, carrying a small suitcase, getting on a bus, like girls in movies leaving home, convents, lovers, I supposed I would get started on my real life.

(Lives, p. 201)

FOOTNOTES

1. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," John Metcalf, *Journal of Canadian Fiction*, 1, No. 4, (Fall, 1972), p. 61
2. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, (Toronto: Anansi, 1973), p. 258
3. Alice Munro, "Who Do You Think You Are? Review-Interview with Alice Munro," Carole Gerson, *Room of One's Own*, Volume 4, No. 4, p. 4
4. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," p. 58
5. Alice Munro, "Name: Alice Munro, Occupation: Writer," *Chatelaine* (August, 1975), p. 71
6. An error by the typesetter of the Signet edition, has resulted in "The Flat Roads" title for this episode
7. Alice Munro, "A Conversation with Alice Munro," p. 59
8. Alice Munro, *Chatelaine*, p. 69
9. *Ibid.*, p. 69
10. *Ibid.*, p. 43

Who Do You Think You Are? (1978)

“The thing she was ashamed of, in acting, was that she might have been paying attention to the wrong things, reporting antics, when there was always something further, a tone, a depth, a light, that she couldn’t get and wouldn’t get. And it wasn’t just about acting she suspected this. Everything she had done could sometimes be seen as a mistake.”

“Who Do You Think You Are?”

p. 209

According to Munro, *Who Do You Think You Are?* is an anthology of linked stories, (unlike *Lives* which is an episodic novel) following Rose past high school, into university, marriage, motherhood, divorce and the ironic self-awareness of middle age, in stories written with Munro's characteristic use of split time with flashbacks, and flashforwards, with each ending in the present reality. Munro wants to show:

the way things change, the way people change from youth to middle age. It seemed to me that it isn't important enough just to write a story about what was happening, like in "Haifa Grapefruit" when Rose was an adolescent. I wanted this to go in a framework, of what the people became, of what the place became.

The fact that Rose's experiences are related as a series of stories rather than as a novel means that certain elements such as elementary school, her courtship and her return home to care for her stepmother are highlighted. Other important aspects of Rose's life — her relationship with her brother, her father's death, her divorce remain undeveloped. Munro said, "it would have weakened the stories as stories,"¹ to have a lot of explanatory paragraphs, "weaving people into the text." Munro explained in an interview that the early reviews on *Who Do You Think You Are?* discuss two protagonists: Janet and Rose. Because Macmillan wanted a book that fall, Munro gave them her manuscript of stories about Rose plus new stories about Janet; it had six Rose stories and five Janet stories. Realizing that "a book of short stories either has to be all separate stories, or if they're linked, they should be linked about one person," Munro at her own expense had the book reset and published featuring only Rose.

Rose is introduced in the first few lines as having, "a need to picture things, to pursue absurdities." As such, she is Munro's persona, like Munro who is "very, very excited by what you call the surface of life. . ." seeking, "to get at the exact tone of texture of how things are."² Rose grows up on the wrong side of the bridge, in West Hanratty, a community of cripples, idiots and misfits in Munro's "other country." She leaves her childhood world — of squalor and scandal, incest in the school outhouse, sex under

the porch — for the clean corridors of university and marriage to the well-to-do Patrick Blatchford. Through metaphors of disguise, verbal masks and role playing, developed earlier in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You*, Munro shows Rose attempting to leave “the other country” and fit into the conventional and comfortable world of conformity. The married and disillusioned Rose unsuccessfully seeks romance with her best friend’s husband. After her marriage ends, she becomes an actress, and a drifter, moving through various unsatisfactory “unconsummated relationships.” Through her experiences, Rose, much like the protagonists in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You* — struggles to define her own identity in relation to the two realities that she perceives, well aware of the anomaly of her position. An awareness of these existential possibilities makes control of one’s life and the act of survival, a challenge. Early in the book, Munro states that this is Rose’s task, “learning to survive, no matter with what craveness and caution, what shocks and foreboding. . .” Rose does learn to survive and accepts finally that she must be alone. Asked if she sees this as the fate of “modern every-woman,” Munro replied that “There are not many men for middle-aged women . . . but I think she wants, in a sense, to keep herself whole, rather than involved. That’s a decision.”³ It is this, “acceptance of the truth of where you are,” that according to Munro is, “the most releasing thing I know.”⁴ Consequently, it can be said that unlike the unresolved conflicts in Munro’s other protagonists, there is an existentialist

According to Munro, *Who Do You Think You Are?* is an anthology of linked stories, (unlike *Lives* which is an episodic novel) following Rose past high school, into university, marriage, motherhood, divorce and the ironic self-awareness of middle age, in stories written with Munro’s characteristic use of split time with flashbacks, and flashforwards, with each ending in the present reality. Munro wants to show:

the way things change, the way people change from youth to middle age. It seemed to me that it isn’t important enough just to write a story about what was happening, like in “Half a Grapefruit” when Rose was an adolescent. I wanted this to go in a framework, of what the people became, of what the place became.

The fact that Rose's experiences are related as a series of stories rather than as a novel means that certain elements such as elementary school, her courtship and her return home to care for her stepmother are highlighted. Other important aspects of Rose's life — her relationship with her brother, her father's death, her divorce remain undeveloped. Munro said, "it would have weakened the stories as stories,"¹ to have a lot of explanatory paragraphs, "weaving people into the text." Munro explained in an interview that the early reviews on *Who Do You Think You Are?* discuss two protagonists: Janet and Rose. Because Macmillan wanted a book that fall, Munro gave them her manuscript of stories about Rose plus new stories about Janet; it had six Rose stories and five Janet stories. Realizing that "a book of short stories either has to be all separate stories, or if they're linked, they should be linked about one person," Munro at her own expense had the book reset resolution in Rose.

"Who do you think you are?" is a question addressed to Rose in the first story and again in the last. In West Hanratty, the expression is a warning not to step outside the acceptable patterns of behaviour. It is in places like West Hanratty, however, that people do indeed know who they are. Rose leaves seeking another reality and finally returns home to discover who she really is. Munro says of Flo: "She's very strong; she's very simple in a way. I mean she's complex, but she's direct. She's unintellectual and quite unreflective, natural."⁵ West Hanratty, typified by Flo and her stories of its inhabitants is Munro's "other country," natural and disordered. The distinction between the incompatible realities of "the other country" and "the world" becomes evident when Rose leaves town to live with Dr. Henshawe where she sits, "in the dining room with a linen napkin on her knee, eating from fine white plates on blue placemats."

Dr. Henshawe's house had done one thing. It had destroyed the naturalness, the taken-for-granted background, of home. To go back there was to go quite literally into a crude light. . . . What Dr. Henshawe's house and Flo's did best, in Rose's opinion, was discredit each other. In Dr. Henshawe's charming rooms there was always for Rose the raw knowledge of home, an indigestible lump,

and at home, now, her sense of order and modulation elsewhere exposed such embarrassing, sad poverty.

(*Who*, p. 69)

However, Rose aspires to belong to the social garrison. Earlier at school as a child, Rose, like a host of Munro's protagonists before her, wanted, "to align herself with the towners, against her place or origin, to attach herself to those waffle-eating, coffee-drinking, aloof and knowledgeable possessors of breakfast nooks."

Like Mr. Loughheed in "Walking on Water," and the narrator in "Tell Me Yes or No," Rose must also try to reconcile a vision of reality on different cognitive time levels. When Rose looks back at West Hanratty during the war years and during the years before:

the two times were so separate it was as if an entirely different lighting had been used . . . so that on the one hand things looked clean-edged, and decent and limited and ordinary and on the other, dark, grainy, jumbled and disturbing.

(*Who*, p. 38)

While the collection of stories is arranged chronologically, nevertheless, the stories contain Munro's characteristic shifts of time in flashbacks and flashforwards, further contributing to a sense of split reality in the mind of the reader.

Flo's stories of the inhabitants present the reader with, "the dark, grainy, jumbled and disturbing" side of life in West Hanratty. Becky Tyde is one such inhabitant: a big-headed, loud-voiced deformed dwarf who reportedly had borne a child, fathered by her own father, who was beaten to death by three townsfolk while Becky watched impassionately. In another of her stories, Fanny McGill (so Flo said) had been smashed against the wall by her drunken father and consequently her face was badly deformed, "her nose crooked, making every breath she took a long dismal-sounding snuffle." According to Flo, she was "performing" with her brother Shortie, in the outhouse. Munro believes that women have "a clarity of vision" that "goes along with a lack of power."⁶ Flo certainly is able to see through the

pretensions and inappropriate dress of Rose's school idol, Cora, whose father is "the town honey-dumper." Flo's prediction that, "she is going to turn out a monster of fat" proves true. More importantly, she sees what Rose must learn, that "it was the enslavement, the self-abasement, the self-deception of love that she sickened at. . . She saw the danger all right." Flo's end is "dark and disturbing" as she, like Hat Nettleton, one of the horsewhippers of Becky's father, is incarcerated in The Home, where she stops talking and spends most of her time "sitting in a corner of the crib, looking crafty and disagreeable . . . and occasionally showed her feelings by biting a nurse."

As a teenager, Munro felt that she had

a different view of the world, and one that would bring me into great trouble and ridicule if it were exposed. I learned very early to disguise everything and perhaps the escape into making stories was necessary.⁷

Rose, too, chooses to escape the reality of this world hoping to find acceptance in the conventional world first by her fantasy role playing, then her social role playing and later professional role playing as an actress. Thus, Munro links these stories together, not only through a single protagonist and the development of one basic plot line but also through her most strident use to date of extended theatrical metaphors initiated in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and developed further in *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You*. Consequently, in contrast to Flo's simple and direct manner, Rose discovers that because of her role playing, her life is a series of "true lies" and that ultimately, "the betrayal was hers." Without order, limits and roles, we know we are inviting the hazardous and lonely existential quest of self-determination. Rose seeks roles to avoid that very quest, while at the same time paradoxically finding herself, because of her questing nature, drawn closer to that truth as she journeys in the book from one experience to another, "learning to survive." One such lucid moment occurs in "Spelling" near the end of the book. Reading a letter from Flo aloud to her friends for "dramatic effect to show the gulf that lay behind her," she stops reading halfway; stopped by that gulf, "she had a fresh and overwhelming realization of it and it was nothing to laugh at." Flo's

reproaches in the letter were, “painfully, truly meant; they were all a hard life had to offer.”

In the first story, “Royal Beatings,” Rose, just as characters in Munro’s previous stories do, sees herself “at the mercy.” She feels her wrangles with Flo have been, “going on forever, like a dream that goes back and back into other dreams, over hills and through doorways, maddeningly dim and populous and familiar and elusive.” This idea that life, “can’t be stopped, can never be stopped, short of where it has got to, now” runs throughout all the stories in this anthology, just as it does in Munro’s other stories, establishing Rose as an insightful character like Eileen in “Memorial” and the narrator in “The Spanish Lady” who are aware of the chaotic reality of life, in contrast to those like June in “Memorial” and her “insistence on control,” and the grandmother and her ideal of order in “Winter Wind”: characters who refuse to contemplate any reality other than their own. Rose sees herself and others as playing roles in “a story line.” Her father is, “like a bad actor, who turns a part grotesque” and Rose must play her part in “the royal beatings” with “the same grossness . . . she must play his victim.” While he slaps and kicks her, ignoring Flo’s rehearsed and theatrical protests, he never really hurts Rose because after all “the royal beatings” are only staged; afterwards, they sit around as though nothing had happened because, “life has started up again,” life that is by inference staged.

The first story written in this collection was “Privilege” which Munro thought of as “an autobiographical piece, not fiction at all.” She had visited the school and saw a lot of things she had forgotten about or seen from a different perspective. “The story just sort of grew out of the material.” It’s the most autobiographical story in the collection.”⁸ In “Privilege,” Rose’s infatuation with Cora, one of the older girls, results in more fantasy role playing; “she spent her time trying to walk and look like Cora, repeating every word she had ever heard her say. Try to be her.” She imagines she is sick and Cora will be called to look after her. After a clumsy attempt to give Cora a gift of candy stolen from Flo’s store, Rose is begrudgingly shamed into recognizing Cora for the pretentious phoney she is. In many ways this episode is microcosmic of the book’s thematic line. Rose becomes infatuated with the pretentious “world,” and adapts mimicking roles in order to gain acceptance, until the reality of Flo’s wisdom and her world really sinks in, and Rose accepts herself, her limitations and a new vision.

Partly as escape from the poverty of her home and Flo's no-nonsense approach to life, Rose also escapes into the fantasy world of the books she reads at school. She imagines, not that she is playing Lady Macbeth, but that "she imagined herself being her, being Lady Macbeth"; in "Half a Grapefruit," when her father is about to be taken to hospital for treatment of his terminal lung cancer, Rose "dramatized her own part in it," seeing herself, "young in years but old in bitter experience of life." She sits reciting Lady Macbeth's lines:

Come to my woman's breasts
And take my milk for gall, you murdering ministers.

thinking what a "jolt" it would give them, if she yelled that into the kitchen as Flo and Billy Pope sit solemnly awaiting her father's departure. In her adolescence, Rose believes it would be, "an especially fine thing to manage a transformation . . . to dare it; to get away with it, to enter on preposterous adventures in your own but newly named skin."

These fantasy roles are harmless because they are largely within Rose's imagination. However, when she leaves West Hanratty for university, Rose starts her self-destructive social role playing in earnest with Patrick Blatchford who was courting her. Explaining to him in "The Beggar Maid," "we came from two different worlds . . . she felt like a character in a play saying that." Ironically, in truth they do come from two different worlds: Rose from Munro's "other country" and Patrick from "the world," a division that is apparent in the reciprocated visits to each other's home. She realizes that, "she was the one who was being dishonest, pretending to throw herself on his mercy." Visiting his affluent parents' home, Rose, "had never before known how some places could choke you, choke off your very life." She observes the wrangling among the family members and decides she had never imagined "so much malevolence collected in one place" and by comparison, "her own people seemed jovial and content." Yet when she takes Patrick to West Hanratty, she is ashamed of the way her family talked, the food, the decor, and Flo's timidity. When Patrick remarks on the trip home, "You were right . . . it is a dump," she does not protest. Rose thinks, what a coward he was but she knew that she herself was the coward, not knowing any way to be comfortable with her own people. Despite her views

of Patrick as “full of cruel judgements,” and “full of conceit” and marriage to him not what she wanted, when they become officially engaged, “she dimpled and sparkled and turned herself into a fiancé with no trouble at all.” Even in their love making, she counterfeits pleasure aware that, “the deceits and stratagems were only hers. Patrick was never a fraud,” but she doesn’t know what to do without his love and the role of “wife, sweetheart” is just too enticing to refuse. Rose finds the resultant role of wife, however, for the next ten years less palatable, with its constant wrangling, beatings and a half-hearted attempted suicide. “She had scars on her wrists and body, which she had made (not quite in the most dangerous places) with a razor blade.” Even efforts at reconciliation are “a sham.”

“Mischief” is a transitional story between her courtship in “The Beggar Maid” and her separation in “Providence,” in which she attempts unsuccessfully to find something to fill that, “cold and hurtful need” by an affair with Clifford, a transitional period which Rose later recalls as, “the start of wrecks and changes, the start of being where she is now instead of in Patrick’s house.” Unlike Patrick who is “simple, pure and trustworthy,” Clifford had “taken on a role” and is described as “adept at disguises, as Rose thought she herself was getting to be.”

Rose who longs to say witty and acceptable things at parties cringes inwardly at Patrick’s lack of social pretenses, disassociating herself from him, preferring instead to be “playing the game of watching Clifford, while pretending not to watch him.” Ironically, Rose who in real life is becoming so adept at role playing in fact, “wanted to be an actress,” but “never tried to act, was afraid to go near the college drama productions” and tells Clifford’s wife that, “she was too much of a coward ever to walk on a stage.” As Rose plans her rendezvous with Clifford while carrying on her friendship with Jocelyn, she realizes that, “deceitfulness concealment come marvelously easy to her.” Repeated attempts at consummation of the affair, however, fail until finally Clifford ends the affair with Rose doing “some sort of imitation of Barbara Stanwyck perhaps in similar circumstances.” It is during this period of her life that Rose finds herself in a no-man’s land, acquiescing socially to the pretensions of her well-to-do friends, yet hating her house with its gaudy chandelier, the powder room with concealed lighting, the small illuminated fountain — Neptune with a fig leaf — in the garden; playing the role of faithful wife while secretly scornful of Patrick

and his “bare face” frankness, desirous of “tricks, a glittering secret, tender celebrations of lust, a regular conflagration of adultery” she wears “dramatic sexually advertising clothes . . . a disguise.” “Insufficiently tolerant of the natural chaos and refuse of life,” she clings to her external role playing, trying to fit every event, “into the order of things that she knew.”

The realization that her marriage is “fraud for everyone” precipitates Rose’s departure with Anna, their daughter. Rose refuses to accept the responsibility for the breakdown of her marriage despite her awareness that, “even on her wedding day she had known this time would come and that if it didn’t she might as well be dead.” She believes instead in a fatalistic notion, that she had not planned the break but instead, “it had happened as painfully and ruinously as possible” as something, “that would have to come.”

The break from Patrick is the beginning of a break from a fraudulent life of “true lies.” Ironically, as Rose casts off social roles Munro moves her progressively to achieving her adolescent fantasy of becoming an actress, by acting in radio plays. She still is “too much of a coward to walk on a stage”; though, later she does become a stage and film actress (even baring her breasts in film.) Munro also moves her progressively, geographically towards solitary life in the country. In “Providence,” Rose finds life in a small town more authentic than in cities where, “you have the idea that everything is comprehensible and easy there, almost as if some people have got together and said, ‘Let’s play Town.’ You think that nobody could die there.” However, the bohemian life in a small rented apartment in a small town far from her friends is no life for her daughter Anna. Rose takes another step forward when she accepts that she wants, “to fill her life with Anna,” rather than face the consequences of her choice — alone. Anna returns home to Patrick and his new wife. Symbolically, the story ends with the spotted and then the orange goldfish bought for Anna dying leaving only one, “swollen, bug-eyes baleful and at ease, commanding the whole fishbowl for its own.”

The story that follows, “Simon’s Luck,” is a pivotal story in Rose’s awareness. Munro revised the book, eliminating the Janet stories, adding what she feels is a crucial story. Eight of the ten stories were published elsewhere prior to publication of *Who Do You Think You Are?* in the fall of

1978. Only “Simon’s Luck” and “Who Do You Think You Are?” were not published earlier. Because of its crucial revelations to Rose’s awareness, one can surmise that “Simon’s Luck” is the added story that Munro talks about.⁹ Rose is living alone and often lonely, “upcountry” teaching drama at a community college; she still paradoxically yearns for social acceptance from the very people she disdains for their affectations:

Rose knew by now that when she found people affected . . . their rooms coyly decorated, their manner of living irritating, . . . it was usually because, she Rose, hadn’t received and was afraid she wouldn’t receive the attention she wanted; hadn’t penetrated the party, felt that she might be doomed to hang around on the fringe of things, making judgements.

(*Who*, p. 158)

Rose at the cocktail party in “Simon’s Luck,” despite it all, is still Rose years earlier at the cocktail party in “Mischief.” Very little other than Rose’s awareness of what is happening, has changed. She finds her life has now settled into “a low steady hum of uneasiness, fatigue and apprehension.” A short, intensive and idyllic affair with Simon follows this party, with Rose seeing Simon in various roles as The Humble Workman, The Old Philosopher, The Mad Satyr, abrogating control to Simon who suggests ways of fixing-up her house and planting a garden. When he doesn’t return the following weekend, she muses that, “it seemed she never learned any lessons at all. She had turned Simon into the peg on which her hopes were hung and she could never manage now to turn him back into himself.” Rationalizing it is “better to lose him now” and spare herself, “the serious, commonplace, miserable ritual” of anxious love, she packs and drives to the west coast during the night, stopping only when, “it seemed the world had stopped being a stage where she might meet him.” Then, she realizes why she has run; not only from “the disappointment, the losses, the disillusion, nor from the opposite of those things; the celebration and shock of love.” She runs desperately trying to control, “a private balance spring, a little dry kernel of probity.” A year later, she learns with a shock how disordered reality is and how little one can control, when she learns of Simon’s death

from cancer. On location doing a film when she hears the news, Rose muses that in the dramatic arts:

People watching trusted that they would be protected from predictable disasters, also from those shifts of emphasis that throw the story line open to question, the disarrangement which demand new judgements, and solutions . . . Simon's dying struck Rose as that kind of disarrangement. It was preposterous, it was unfair, that such a chunk of information should have been left out and that Rose even at this late date could have thought herself the only person who could seriously lack power.

(*Who*, p. 177)

In her adolescent fantasies, Rose saw her perceived roles as more real than her own reality, but now her real acting roles, she perceives as less fantastical than reality. This whole incident throws "the story line" open to "new judgements and solutions."

Munro masterfully shifts immediately in "Spelling" to the reality of West Hanratty and Rose's return after an absence of two years, to care for Flo who has become so senile, her hair has grown up through a hat that has rotted on her head and who doesn't even recognize Rose. Flashbacks juxtapose the two realities, showing Flo's "painfully, truly meant" letter of reproach to Rose who had read the letter aloud for "comic effect" exposing and making fun of Flo to her city friends; another flashback features Flo, wearing a mauve and purple checked pant-suit, her hair covered by a grey wig pulled low on her forehead looking like a comic character, and obviously aware that she is not fitting into the pretentious group of Rose's friends at an awards dinner in Toronto. Juxtaposed with the sincerity of Flo's simple lifestyle and home with its calendar with a picture of a puppy, a photograph of Princess Anne, a Blue Mountain vase, with three yellow plastic roses — all mementos with personal meanings to Flo, is the falseness of Rose's past two years, travelling for two years with an acting company chatting on TV about these productions, trying to drum up interest. "There was nothing shameful about any of this, but sometimes Rose was deeply unaccountably ashamed." She hid her confusion in public

being “frank” and “charming.” Sadly, “she couldn’t remember any of the people she had met, the charming, interesting people who had invited her to dinner and to whom, over drinks in various cities, she told intimate things about her life.” “Spelling” also juxtaposes Rose’s unstable, theatrical life with Brian’s suburban life of “perfectly justified self satisfaction.” Rose envisions herself in a role bound to win Brian and Phoebe’s admiration. She would go to Hanratty and live the rest of her life looking after Flo.

Finally Rose must place Flo in The Home. There, Munro’s representation of the irreconcilable realities culminates in her description of the old woman who can’t see or communicate in any way except by spelling words she hears.

It seemed she had only the thinnest thread to follow, meandering through that emptiness or confusion that nobody on this side can do more than guess at. But she didn’t lose it, she followed it through to the end, however tricky the word might be, or cumbersome. . . . Did they carry their usual meaning, or any meaning at all? Were they like words in dreams or in the minds of young children, each one marvelous and distinct and alive as a new animal? . . . A parade of private visitors, not over yet.

(*Who*, p. 188)

Just as the musical Dance of The Happy Shades performed by the retarded Delores in “Dance of The Happy Shades,” and the strange ballet dance performed for Del by the mad Bobby Sheriff at the conclusion of *Lives of Girls and Women* are communiqués from Munro’s “other country,” so to is the faultless spelling by the old woman. Just as Del admits that Bobby’s dance seemed “to have a concise meaning, a stylized meaning — to be a letter; or a whole word, in an alphabet I did not know,” so too, Rose is unsure if the words spelled by the old woman contain “their usual meaning or any meaning at all? Were they like words in dreams or in the minds of young children, each one marvelous and distinct and alive as a new animal?” Munro shows that there is another reality perhaps only fully perceived and understood by those who inhabit it, undauntingly entertaining their own “parade of private visitors.”

The book ends where it begins, in flashbacks to Rose's youth with stories in "Who Do You Think You Are?" about "a parade of private visitors" of sorts, the inhabitants of West Hanratty who like Milton Homer lack, "a sense of precaution and a sense of social inhibition," and with Rose's adolescent desire to act evidenced in her admiration of Ralph Gillespie who could do marvelous imitations of the townsfolk. "She wanted to fill up in that magical, releasing way, transform herself; she wanted the courage and the power." The reader, having seen the devastating results of Rose's role playing in real life and her lack of power to control her own "parade of private visitors," is prepared to accept Rose's conclusion that

The thing she was ashamed of in acting was that she might have been paying attention to the wrong things, reporting antics, when there was always something further, a tone, a depth, a light, that she couldn't get and wouldn't get. And it wasn't just about acting she suspected this. Everything she had done could sometimes be seen as a mistake.

(*Who*, p. 209)

FOOTNOTES

1. Alice Munro, “Who Do You Think You Are? Review-Interview with Alice Munro,” *Room of One’s Own*, 4, No. 4, (1979), p. 4
2. Alice Munro, interviewed by Gareme Gibson, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, Toronto, Anansi (1973), p. 241
3. Alice Munro, *Room of One’s Own*, p. 6
4. Alice Munro, interviewed by Ken Murch, “Name: Alice Munro, Occupation: Writer.” *Chatelaine* (August, 1975), p. 70
5. Alice Munro, *Room of One’s Own*, p. 7
6. Alice Munro, *Chatelaine*, p. 72
7. Alice Munro, *Eleven Canadian Novelists*, p. 246
8. Alice Munro, *Room of One’s Own*, p. 6
9. Alice Munro, “The Past, the Present and Alice Munro,” *Saturday Night* (November, 1979), p. 17

The Moons of Jupiter (1982)

“It strikes me that misplacement is the clue, in love, the heart of the problem, but like somebody drunk or high I can’t quite get a grasp on what I see”

“Bardon Bus”

p. 128

All of Alice Munro's previous collections have dealt with the problems of recognizing and confronting reality on its different cognitive levels. Likewise, the twelve stories in *The Moons of Jupiter*, published in 1982, deal with characteristically female protagonists but this time in a wider range of experience. Some stories like "The Turkey Season" and "Chaddeleys and Flemings" are about childhood and adolescent memories coloured now with the more mature perspective of hindsight that experience brings, reminiscent of Munro's stories in *Dance of The Happy Shades* and *Something I've Been Meaning to Tell You*. Other protagonists like the narrators in "Hard Luck Stories" and "Bardon Bus" are older, divorced or separated women with grown families, but like Munro's earlier protagonists, still measuring in acute introspection present reality in terms of past memories, striving to ascertain "true memory," ultimately seeking "connections" but now with more insight, often at times self-deprecating and cynically expressed, cognizant that a belief "in perfect mastery" is "a fantasy"; life after all holds few "clear moments of authority." Perhaps as Munro suggests in "Prue" life can only be measured in anecdotes in which, "hopes are dashed, dreams ridiculed, things never turn out as expected, everything is altered in a bizarre way and there is no explanation ever." Other stories, like "Visitors" and "Mrs. Cross and Mrs. Kidd," are about elderly people and like half of the stories in this collection (unlike her earlier volumes of collected stories with their predominant use of first person narrative) are written in the third person, still nevertheless with Munro's characteristic perspective of split time measuring present "realities" in terms of the fluidity of the past. Munro's previous highly acclaimed and innovative use of linked stories in *Lives of Girls and Women* and *Who Do You Think You Are?* is still evident in this collection. The first story, "Chaddeleys and Flemings" is actually two linked stories titled "1. Connection" and "2. The Stone in the Field" (both of which were published separately previously). These stories are linked in turn to "The Moons of Jupiter," the last story, giving a sense of cohesion, through recurrent images and episodes to an otherwise diverse collection of stories. In fact, ten of the twelve stories were published previously, separately, dating from the publication of "Accident" in 1977 to "Mrs. Cross and Mrs. Kidd" in 1982,

giving the reader a good cross sampling — a retrospective — of Munro's art as a short story writer.

Her self-acknowledged strength as a regional writer is evident in her descriptions of the small town and rural settings of Logan in "Visitors," and Dalgleish in "Chaddeleys and Flemings." "Accident" takes place in 1943 in Hanratty, the mythical small town setting of *Who Do You Think You Are?* Characters in "Dulse" set in rural New Brunswick, also seem like Herb Abbott in "The Turkey Season," Iris in "Connection" and Poppy in "The Stone in the Field," to be genuine, spontaneous people. Other stories like "Bardon Bus" and "Hard Luck Stories" set in Toronto and Vancouver (perhaps coinciding in time with her protagonists' sense of "unconsummated relationships") are inhabited by people whose faces are "clamped down on their secrets." Regardless of the setting, however, Munro's characters as in all of her work, (although to a less strident extent than in her earlier stories) still inhabit a world seen as having an essential and irreconcilable tension between two sets of values: conventional morality and individual freedom.

All of these stories are written with Munro's characteristic metaphoric implicitness, sensitivity, and compactness of language, rich in vivid images, evoking a subtle humourous tone which pervades so many of her memorable stories. In fact Munro describes *The Moons of Jupiter*, not as "gloomy," but as "a funny book." It is characteristic of Munro's paradoxical vision to see the comic and the tragic simultaneously. In "Connection," the protagonist hurls a Pyrex plate at her husband's head. Unfortunately, the piece of pie flew out and "caught him in the side of his face just as in the old movies or an T Love Lucy Show'." The protagonist reveals, however, the amazement she felt that "something people invariably thought funny in those instances should be so shocking a verdict in real life."

While *The Moons of Jupiter* contains characters and techniques typically Munro, it does contain stories, however, that show a wider range of narrative techniques than seen previously in any one of her collections. "Bardon Bus," for example, is divided into 13 small numbered segments narrated by a protagonist, an intuitive, detached (at times cynical) moral critic commenting philosophically on present action and past experience, in terse, often clipped sentences as she reflects on her reality, "a lifelong secret, lifelong dream-life," in which, typical of Munro's protagonists, she

has sought “shelter.” In thinking of her past relationships, (particularly one with a character she only identifies as X) she compares herself (and women in general) to her friend Kay “who survives without visible damage.” “Labour Day Dinner,” a story about a woman’s growing sense of failure in a relationship with her lover, uses an unusual shifting point of view; narrated in the third person, first from Roberta’s perspective on her relationship, then shifting to George’s, and then Angela’s perception of her mother’s relationship with George, allowing the reader to see the collapsing relationships from all sides. The “ghost car,” destined to cross their homeward path, is described using the omniscient outside point of view. The reader now has a totally different perspective on the situation than the characters who are unaware of the car’s threatening presence. Munro says “When I read fiction I like it to be complex and paradoxical — to open a lot of doors instead of pushing me in one direction.”

“Hard Luck Stories” is narrated in the present tense, by a mature, somewhat cynical woman; as she travels with a friend and her friend’s husband, the two women each tell a story to Douglas — a revealing episode of a failed relationship from the past; this cathartic experience leaves the narrator feeling like all of Munro’s earlier protagonists in *Something I’ve Been Meaning to Tell You* and Rose in *Who Do You Think You Are?*, “stumped by a truth about myself, or at least a fact, that I couldn’t do anything about . . . I could be always bent on knowing and always in the dark.” Munro says:

Everybody knows what a house does, how it encloses space and makes connections between one enclosed space and another and presents what is outside in a new way. This is the nearest I can come to explaining what a story does for me, and what I want my stories to do for other people.

All of the stories illustrate Munro’s on-going concern with “getting rid of masks,” like the protagonist in “Connection,” tearing away “all false notions, all illusions” to an awareness that, “Connection. That was what it was all about . . . a connection with the real and prodigal and dangerous world.”

In “Connection” (the first story of “Chaddeleys and Flemings”) the young narrator describes the antics of four of her mother’s cousins, “maiden ladies they were called. Old maids was too thin a term,” ladies who were “audience and performers” during their summer visit to Dalglish (which they didn’t think was “real”). These four fun-loving characters provided a connection to the outside world for the narrator:

They knew how to get on in it, they had made it take notice. They could command a classroom, a maternity ward, the public; they knew how to deal with taxi drivers and train conductors.

(Moons, p. 7)

Years later, however, she was living in Vancouver, married to Richard, a socially pretentious lawyer, whose family viewed poverty and a poor rural background like “bad breath or running sores, an affliction for which the afflicted must bear one part of the blame.” Richard wanted her “amputated from that past which seemed to him such shabby baggage; he was on the lookout for signs that the amputation was not complete; and of course it wasn’t.” A visit by the effervescent cousin Iris with her bright lipstick, her bright teased hair, her iridescent dress and oversized brooch, her voice and conversation in favour of noise, change, flashiness, hilarity, courage, and fun puts a strain on the narrator’s desire to keep her connections to her own background, her husband’s favour and her memories. However she realizes that she is dishonest in thinking that if she could have met Iris somewhere else she would have appreciated her more, that it was Richard’s judgements that were all that stood in the way:

I had to wonder if this was all it amounted to, the gaiety I remembered; the gaiety and generosity, the worldliness. It would be better to think that time had soured and thinned and made commonplace a brew that used to sparkle, that difficulties had altered us both and not for the better.

(Moons, p. 17)

The narrator recalls her childhood love of looking at magazine advertisements showing ladies in chiffon dresses with capes and floating panels, through which she apprehended a life of elegance and sensibility. They were “a window on the world,” and the cousins were another. Yet in reality, those elegant ladies in advertisements were “discussing underarm odour or thanking their lucky stars they no longer chafed, because they used Kotex,” and just as she does in “The Stone in The Field,” she now questions “true memories.” Despite this insight into her connections with her memories, however, she is not willing to allow Richard to belittle Cousin Iris (the connection with her past) after she leaves and she hurls the Pyrex pie plate at his head when he calls Iris “a pathetic old tart.” Thus, her attempts to reconcile, what are really divergent “connections,” “complicated and varied” — her family background, her husband’s expectations and her own memories — ultimately fail. The stay ends in a powerful metaphor, a juxtaposed flashback; she and her sister lie in bed listening to the singing of a rondeau:

Life is transformed, by these voices; by these presences, by their high spirits, and grand esteem, for themselves and each other. . . The mixture of voices and words is so complicated and varied it seems that such confusion, such jolly rivalry, will go on forever, and then to my surprise — for I am surprised; even though I know the pattern of rounds — the song is thinning out, you can hear two voices striving . . . then there the one voice alone, one of them singing on, gamely, to the finish. One voice in which there is an unexpected note of entreaty, of warning . . . ‘Life is.’ Wait. ‘But a.’ Now, wait, ‘Dream.’

(*Moons*, p. 18)

“2. The Story in the Field” deals with connections to her father’s family centred on memory of an adolescent’s family excursion to the old homestead to visit her father’s five surviving reclusive sisters: odd, stiff women who seemed to be “leftovers” from another austere age in their starched bonnets and aprons and work filled lives. The narrator had difficulty because “The connection seemed impossible” to these women, yet

she recalls an even earlier childhood visit when she and one of these aunts had exchanged a look, “exactly as two children look at each other when an adult is calling.” She is aware that she “must have sensed something unusual about this, some lack of what was expected, even necessary, in the way of balance or barriers.” At the time of her adolescent visit to the farm, however, she didn’t want to accept the physical connection with these women. “They looked a great deal like me. I didn’t know it at the time and wouldn’t have wanted to.” However, years later, receiving a card, and realizing what an act of faith was required for the aunts to go to the Post Office, buy a stamp and send a card to an unimaginable place as Vancouver “to someone of their own blood leading a life so strange to them someone who would read the card with such a feeling of bewilderment and unexplainable guilt. It did make me guilty and bewildered to think they were still there, still attached to me.” Years later, after the death of the aunts, motivated by a chance reading of an old newspaper clipping, to find a boulder in the field under which a hermit is reportedly buried on the old Fleming farm, the more mature narrator, seeks a connection with her father’s family. The farm house is now inhabited by a modern family with two young children and the land successfully farmed by a businessman who owns “a thousand acres in corn in Huron County alone.” The stone is not in the field; probably when the corn was put in the stone was in the way and hauled away. She realizes that if she had been younger she would have made “a horrible, plausible connection between that silence of his and his death.” She would have wanted the hermit to have been in love with one of her aunts and one of them — not necessarily the one he was in love with — being in love with him. Now, however, she can “no longer believe that people’s secrets are defined and communicable or their feelings full-blown and easy to recognize.” Her mother’s family sallied forth “aware of change and possibility”; her father’s family were “perfectly encased in what they had and were.” “However they behaved, they are all dead. I carry something of them around in me.”

“The Moons of Jupiter,” the last story, is linked to “Chaddeleys and Flemings.” The narrator has taken her father from Dalgleish to Toronto to await heart surgery. In “The Stone in The Field” the narrator discussed a conversation she had previously with her father in the hospital concerning his life and his family as she recalls “the poor farm, the scared sisters, the

harsh father.” The reader is reminded of this conversation. “The Moons of Jupiter” ends inconclusively as she awaits the outcome of his operation. However, a reference to the father’s stay in the hospital “for the last time” in the earlier story, implies the outcome. Throughout the story she attempts to avoid connection to “the escaped child, the survivor, an old man trapped here by his leaky heart.” She didn’t “care to think of his younger selves” and even “his bare torso, thick and white — was “a danger” to her. She realizes during this crisis how little she knows her father. She recalls talking to her friends at college and “How thoroughly we dealt with our fathers and mothers and deplored their marriages; their mistaken ambitions or fear of ambition, how competently we filed them away, defined them beyond any possibility of change. What presumption.” She thinks of her relationship with her own two daughters, realizing that while she and her husband have become “a cartoon couple, more middle aged in our twenties than we would be in middle age,” those “bumbling years are the years our children will remember all their lives. Corners of the yards I never visited will stay in their heads.” Now her grown daughter, Nichola, is somewhere “incommunicado.” Just as the young protagonist in “The Turkey Season” is aware that our perceptions of people are often faulty because a person is “not a puzzle so arbitrarily solved” the more mature narrator realizes that just as she goes around saying Nichola is “sly and solitary, cold, seductive” there are many people who must know things that would contradict her perception of her daughter.

Munro uses a trip to the planetarium, “a slightly phony temple,” metaphorically, to show how “realism was abandoned for familiar artifice” in family relationships. Even factual information about the universe given out with such confidence is later found out to be quite wrong. Many of the stories in this volume end inconclusively with similar metaphorical analogies. In “Prue,” the protagonist, is a woman who presents her life in anecdotes where “hopes are dashed, dreams ridiculed, things never turn out as expected, everything is altered in a bizarre way and there is no explanation ever.” She stashed away an old tobacco tin, a cuff-link stolen from her errant lover’s home:

Now the tin has in it several things besides the cufflink — all small things, not of great value but not worthless, either. A little enamelled dish, a sterling-silver spoon for salt, a crystal fish. These are not sentimental keepsakes. She never looks at them, and often forgets what she has there. They are not booty, they don't have ritualistic significance. She does not take something every time she goes to Gordon's house, or every time she stays over, or to mark what she might call memorable visits. She doesn't do it in a daze and she doesn't seem to be under a compulsion. She just takes something, every now and then, and puts it away in the dark of the old tobacco tin, and more or less forgets about it.

(*Moons*, p. 133)

"Hard Luck Stories" ends in a cemetery, with the narrator aware of "a shadow, a chastening" as she hears "the silly sound" of her own voice against "the truth of the lives laid down here. Lives pressed down, like layers of rotting fabric, disintegrating dark leaves." She believes that these "lives would find the three of them "strange, indulged and culpable," and like other Munro protagonists is pleased to discover the familiar, a trillium embroidered on a footstool in the old graveyard church. The trillium is "a homely emblem, among the more ancient and exotic" but of which springs for all of the characters "an unacknowledged spring of hopefulness" as their lives return to the present, familiar reality where perhaps they "could all be happy."

"Visitors" is another story dealing with unconsumed relationships in families, this time between siblings. Wilfred is visited by his brother, Albert, whom he hasn't seen in more than thirty years, accompanied by his wife and her sister. Mildred, Wilfred's wife, muses over the differences between Wilfred and Albert. "Brothers and sisters were a mystery to her. There were Grace and Vera speaking like two mouths out of the same head and Wilfred and Albert without a thread of connection between them." Nevertheless when Albert leaves, Mildred is awakened by Wilfred's crying. The story is narrated in the third person from Mildred's limited perspective, which serves not only to further intensify the reader's sense of Wilfred's disconnection with his brother but also heightens Wilfred's lack of

connection with his wife, a woman he had married after a short courtship of only six weeks:

Any time before, when he had consented to tell her why he was crying, the reason had seemed to her very queer, something thought up on the spur of the moment, or only distantly connected with the real reason. But maybe it was as close as he could get.

(*Moons*, p. 216)

Munro's protagonists are always aware of frustration: the disparity between what is desired and what is attained in relationships. "How attractive, how delectable, the prospect of intimacy is with the very person who will never grant it. I can still feel the pull of a man like that, of his promising and refusing," comments the young narrator in "The Turkey Season." This paradox is shown by Munro to be the fundamental problem in collapsing love relationships depicted in reminiscence of past love affairs by the protagonists in "Dulse," "Bardon Bus," "Hard Luck Stories," and "Labour Day Dinner."

In "Dulse," Lydia had been living with a man in Kingston for the past eighteen months. On a trip alone, to the Maritimes, she wants "to make a living in some new way, cut off from everything she had done before. . . ." Munro alternates flashbacks to life with Duncan and her present limbo state on this trip, as she grapples with her "new strange condition," trying to find answers. "She asks what, and when did the transfer take place, when was the abdication of all pride and sense?"

She recalls after her breakup with Duncan how the smallest daily necessities of shopping and travelling about Toronto seemed to be the most difficult things she had ever done. "She could not make the connection between herself and things outside herself." She saw herself as something "like an egg carton hollowed out in back." In telling the men at the hotel about Duncan's funny stories she had hoped "to show herself attached" but realized that was a mistake. In her new condition she is aware that she had changed; she felt "as if she was muffled up, wrapped in layers and layers of dull knowledge, well protected. It was not altogether a bad thing—."

She wonders if she has hit upon the truth about what she needed and wanted; “should she have fallen in love with and married a man like Vincent; should she have been content with such an arrangement and forgotten about the rest? Should she have stayed in the place where love is managed for you, not gone where you have to invent it and reinvent it, and never know if these efforts will be enough.” Just as other Munro protagonists have done in their relationships Lydia has believed that a man’s love was somewhere inside him and “that by gigantic efforts to please or fits of distress which obliterated all those efforts or tricks of indifference, she could claw or lure it out.” She sacrificed herself to him — in living arrangements, in the matter of friends,. She made him a present of such power than complained relentlessly to herself and finally to him that he had got it. But she doesn’t know anymore now “what is true about any of this.”

Likewise, Roberta’s daughter in “Labour Day Dinner” notes in her journal hat she has seen her mother like Lydia change:

from a person I deeply respected into a person on the verge of being a nervous wreck, if this is love I want no part of it. He wants to enslave her and us all and she walks a tightrope trying to keep him from getting mad. She doesn’t enjoy anything and if you gave her the choice she would like best to lie down in a dark room with a cloth over her eyes and not see anyone or do anything. This is an intelligent woman who used to believe in freedom.

(*Moon*, p. 147)

Roberts feels the strain of a collapsing relationship but doesn’t understand what has gone wrong. She only knows now “no clear moments of authority.” The occasion of a visit to a widowed friend’s house for Labour Day dinner provides the framework of the narrative while Munro focuses, as always, not on intricacies of plot but on character, as she struggles to understand the relationship and the nature of love which she decides is “not kind or honest and does not contribute to happiness in any reliable way.” She recalls her unhappiness with her husband Andrew and now realizes how he must have felt as she set up failures in him in her desire to be rid of him. She feels George is now doing that to her. George, however, can’t

understand how a woman who had seemed to him to be “courageous, truthful, without vanity” could have changed. “How out of this could come such touchiness, tearfulness, weariness, such a threat of collapse.” However, neither communicates these feelings. Only the reader sees the problem from both sides. They remain “pinned down by a murderous silence.” A near collision with a car on the way home leaves the couple at the end of the story feeling strange — “as unconnected with previous and future events as the ghost car was” and like Duncan and Lydia in “Dulse,” believing they can somehow, “pick up the undamaged delight with which they’d started before they began to put each other to other uses.”

Throughout these stories reverberates Munro’s belief that in relationships people’s secrets are not defineable nor are feelings communicable. Because of “the pain of human contact” people seek, like Lydia in “Dulse,” “a lovely, durable shelter” aware like the narrator in “The Stone in The Field” that barriers are “expected, even necessary, in the way of balance,” and it is possible, even “attractive,” as Roberts thinks in “Labour Day Dinner,” that idea of “there being that balance.” The main problem according to Munro is “how to keep oneself from lying.” The Munro protagonist struggles for illumination about herself, about relationships, about life, painfully aware that paradoxically she would “be always bent on knowing and always in the dark.”

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